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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

MUNDUM INT'L ART EXHIBITION KICKS OFF

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 17:

'Mundum International Art Exhibition' organised by Diktel Rupakot Majhuwagadhi municipality of Khotang district has kicked off in Kathmandu today.

President Ramchendra Paudel inaugurated the expo organised at Nepal Art Council, Babarmahal.

On the occasion, Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, Sudan Kirati, expressed the belief that such types of international expo would help promote sustainable tourism development.

"Nepal is rich in nature and culture. Diktel Rupakot Majhuwagadhi municipality has become successful to introducing natural and cultural heritages of Khotang district in a new way through paintings.

Such act will contribute in sustainable tourism development based on nature and culture", he mentioned.

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PHOTO: RSS

An aerial view of Gandaki Mata Temple in Panchkot of Baglung district.

PM urges artistes to guard against 'viral' tendency

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 17



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' said that folk songs represent the shared culture and heritage of all Nepalis.

Inaugurating an Open Duet Folk Song Competition organised by the National Folk and Duet Song Academy in Kathmandu on Saturday, the Prime Minister said that folk songs were popular among all languages, ethnicities and regions. However, one should be aware of the external influences and cultural distortions and misrepresentations in the field of folk music, he added.

Stating that progress was made in music based on diverse originality, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "Timeless songs which won the hearts of music admires are deeply rooted in the Nepali spirit.

However, many renowned national artistes have shifted towards cultural distortion to become 'viral' and gain 'views'. Both artistes and the general public need to be aware of this."

Stating that becoming 'viral' and 'beloved' were two different terms, the Prime Minister said that 'viral' denotes an infectious spread and was not good at all.

The Prime Minister said, "Folk songs are the most enriched form of expression within folk literature. They represent the entirety of Nepali lifestyle and are spread from Mechi to Mahakali and even beyond Nepal, reflecting every culture, natural beauty, life events and experiences of joy and sorrow."

He pointed to the need to preserve the originality of folk songs which are also the main basis of the country's national identity.

He said, "Every country has its own folk culture with factors such as necessity, geographical condition, ethnic diversity and cultural values determining its cultural identity. Among the countries with diverse cultures, Nepal stands out as a country where linguistic, cultural and geographical diversities create a strong integration and unity."

Stating that such competitions provide opportunities for people to show their hidden talent, he stressed the need to utilisation of the folk musical instruments for the preservation of folk music.

Stressing the importance of instilling a sense of nationalism and appreciation for originality among all Nepalis, he expressed confidence in advancing towards his goal of fostering unity with concerted efforts.

Construction business facing unprecedented downturn

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 17

The construction industry in Nepal has been facing an unprecedented crisis which entrepreneurs call an 'existential' one. Overall, the construction business in the last year has been whittled down to a third of the total activities.

While it is the primary stakeholder in mobilising the government's capital allocation (which is Rs. 302 billion for the current Fiscal Year 2023/24), it creates a market for construction materials, and other items like pipes and fittings, paints and electric products.

However, in the past more than one year's period, both the public and private construction business has been slowed down.

This distress in the construction industry has its spillover effects on the business of construction materials like cement, iron bars, paints, pipes and fittings, electric goods, furniture and decorative items.

Number of contractors in Nepal by 2023

Categories	Numbers	% in Total	Project Size (Rs.)
Class A	341	1	>200 million
Class B	273	1	6 million-300 million
Class C	1072	5	2 million-100million
Class D	22,152	93	< 3 million

Source: FCAN



Photo: RSS

TRN SPECIAL

For example, the business of pipes and fittings has gone down by 40-50 per cent. "Business has decreased significantly. People are not building private houses, only medium and large industries and a couple of housing projects have continued with construction and maintenance works," said Dipendra Poudel, Managing Director of Kamakhya Trade Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu.

A study by the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) has found that the manufacturing sector in the country was running on an average of 42 per cent in the first half of the last Fiscal Year 2022/23. Likewise, approval for the map of house construction was down by 37.5 per cent during the same period. The situation has further deteriorated in the following months, said Er. Dhruba Thapa, President of the Cement Manufacturers Association (CMA).

While the installed capacity of cement industries has crossed the total domestic demand and the manufacturers have been urging the government to find alternatives like building concrete roads instead of asphalt to increase the demand, the recent recession in construction and development has intensified the crisis in the industries.

Iron bar industries are also experiencing the same crisis. Pashupati Murarka, former President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) who heads Murarka Organization that also operates an iron and steel industry, said that the steel industry is running below 40 per cent of its capacity. In the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, the industries were running at about 90 per cent.

"The market has gone down as there are less construction works, increased number of steel industries, government's failure to spend the budget and liquidity on the part of common people," said Murarka.

Meanwhile, iron industries that relied on MS Billet to produce rods have been on the verge of collapse as the government two years ago abolished the customs duty on sponge iron but continued a 5 per cent import duty and Rs. 2.5 per kg excise duty on MS Billets, another raw material for iron bars.

Kiran Sakha, Managing Director of Sakha Steel, said that the government has been highly apathetic to their problems. Half of the 32 steel industries are in crisis due to the government's decision to exempt duty on sponge iron, implemented through the budget announced by then Finance Minister Janardan Sharma.

This many-sided recession in construction and manufacturing has resulted in the loss of jobs of about 1.5 million people, with about a million losing their jobs in the construction sector alone.

According to Rabi Singh, President of the Federation of Contractors Associations of Nepal (FCAN), the construction industry was providing direct employment to 2 to 2.5 million people. This job loss is seen across various sectors of manufacturing, and supporting activities like transportation, house wiring, painting and furniture.

FCAN said that about 1,800 projects of about Rs. 400 billion are awaiting deadline extension from the government. Likewise, the government has a liability to clear Rs. 40 billion to the contractors. Furthermore, the contractors have not been paid about Rs. 10 billion for the ongoing projects.

The FCAN also said that the construction of about 800 projects is pending as the government couldn't clear the land, assure the budget and provide appropriate design. It is pressing the government for the extension of deadlines for the projects that suffered a backlog of about 9 months to 1 year due to the government restrictions on crusher industries that resulted in a shortage of stones, sand and gravel, and construction couldn't be continued.

The Ministry of Home Affairs in January 2023 had decided to close all crusher industries and quarry works operating illegally. A large number of crusher industries fell in the illegal category due to the provision of a 2-kilometre distance from villages, educational institutions, religious and cultural areas, forests and security establishments, and 500-metre far from river banks and highways. Most of the crusher industries are near rivers, forests, human settlements or highways.

Loans to private sector

Statistics on loan mobilisation are not encouraging either. Domestic credit increased 2.6 per cent in the first half of this FY 2023/24 compared to an increase of 2.8 per cent in the corresponding

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Home Ministry forms committee for police adjustment process

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 17

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MoHA) has announced the initiation of the police personnel adjustment process in accordance with constitutional provisions.

Spokesperson and Joint Secretary Narayan Prasad Bhattarai issued a statement on Friday, confirming the commencement of the adjustment process by designating a five-member committee.

The committee, chaired by the head of the administration division of the Ministry, comprises members from various divisions including policy, planning, monitoring and evaluation, as well as representatives from the Nepal Police and Provincial Police Services.

The name of the coordinator or chair leading the committee is yet to be confirmed as there is no joint secretary deputed at the administration division of the Home Ministry.

However, Thaneshwar Gautam, Joint Secretary of the Home Ministry under the Policy, Planning, Monitoring and Evaluation Division is given responsibility as co-chair or joint coordinator of the committee.

Similarly, one DIG from the Nepal Police and an Under-Secretary from the Ministry working at the Police Employees Section is given the responsibility of member-secretary of the committee and one senior police officer from the provincial Police Office as member, according to Spokesperson and Joint Secretary Bhattarai.

Bhattarai emphasised the Ministry's commitment to carrying out the adjustment of police personnel in alignment with the Constitution and the Nepal Police (Province Police Operation and Coordination) Act, 2076.

The adjustment process aims to streamline the deployment of police personnel within Nepal Police and Provincial Police Services, ensuring efficient and effective law enforcement across the nation.

The federal government has to adjust 54,720 police into the province police offices out of a total of 79541 vacancies in Nepal Police. Of them, 10,717 in Koshi province, 9,152 in Madhes, 7,304 in Bagmati, 6745 in Gandaki, 9443 in Lumbini, 5458 in Karnali and 5901 in Karnali province are going to be adjusted.

NELTA conference kicks off

BY A STAFF REPORTER
LALITPUR, Feb. 17

Nepal English Language Teachers Association (NELTA) started its 28th NELTA International English Language Conference on Saturday at DAV Sushil Kedia Vishwa Bharati School, Jawalakhel, Lalitpur.

The conference will be held from 17-19 February on the theme of 'Rethinking ELT in Diversity: Equity, Inclusion, and Innovation'. According to the organisers around 1000 scholar-teachers of English, teacher trainers, educators, ELT practitioners, and professionals from home (60 districts) and abroad are participating in the conference.

The conference will comprise keynote and plenary speeches, engaging panel discussions, parallel sessions, interactive workshops, enlightening poster presentations, and welcoming social events and book exhibitions.

Damodar Regmi, a central member of the NELTA, said that the conference will foster a collaborative environment for the exchange of insights, networking opportunities, and educational enrichment, while also providing a platform for mutual learning and growth. Participants will have the privilege of connecting with peers, and experts from the USA, as well as from other countries around the world, exchanging perspectives on challenges,

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Save pangolins from poaching and illegal trade: Conservationists

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 17



To raise awareness about pangolins and conservation efforts to help protect the species, World Pangolin Day is celebrated annually on the third Saturday in February across the world.

In Nepal, Greenhood Nepal initiated the annual Pangolin Roundtable in 2015, which brings diverse stakeholders together to discuss pangolin conservation challenges and possible solutions.

Greenhood Nepal and Panchpandab Buffer Zone User's Committee of Chitwan National Park (CNP) in Madi organised this year's Pangolin Roundtable on World Pangolin Day, on Saturday.

The roundtable discussed pangolin conservation in CNP and surrounding buffer zone areas with key researchers, policymakers and local communities to provide a diverse perspective on the challenges of local communities in pangolin conservation, to identify knowledge gaps and explore conservation strategy and policies required for long-term pangolin conservation, said conservationist Kumar Poudel, founder and director of the Greenhood Nepal.

The event was attended by national park officials, Nepal Army, Armed Police Force, Nepal Police, community-based poaching units and local people.

According to Poudel, CNP is known for its success in bringing back rhinos and tiger populations from the brink of extinction, but it is yet to see how this park will also protect critically endangered pangolins.

He said, Greenhood Nepal is working with the park and local communities to understand the pangolin distribution in the park and also to help save pangolins.

Nepal is home to two pangolin species – Chinese pangolin and Indian pangolin. Both species are protected under the Nepal Parks and Wildlife Conservation Act, and listed in Appendix I of the CITES.

Pangolins are widespread across Nepal in more than 60 districts, but protecting them outside the protected areas is becoming challenging due to poaching and illegal trade.

CNP could be a safe home for pangolins if acted on time to protect the remaining pangolin population and habitat, he added.

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(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 117,100
Worked Gold	: Rs. 116,550
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STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,062.03
Total Amount	: 3,869,118,741.98
No. of Share	: 11,407,264

Keep microfinance free from politics: Dr. Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 17

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that microfinance has enhanced people's access to finance in remote areas.

Speaking at the fourth National Microfinance Members Conference that kicked off in Kathmandu on Saturday, he said, "The microfinance sector has supported the underprivileged, poor and women of Nepal and also played an important role in livelihood enhancement."

However, he said that the recent problems in the microfinance institutions (MFIs) have been a matter of concern for everyone. "It has been seen that interest groups are trying to mislead people by showing some problems. We will never allow those who try to politicize a good business sector like microfinance to succeed," FM Dr. Mahat said.

According to him, it is a dangerous tendency to incite people for the non-payment of debts. The government will not remain silent, and all stakeholders, including the companies and members, should collaborate to defeat such forces.

FM Dr. Mahat also urged common debtors not to be under the illusion that they need not pay their debts. "The loan taken from the depositors' savings is never waived. Instead, the government is ready to facilitate in the repayment process. Debt must be paid," he said.

He also urged that microfinance should not be taken as a profit-making tool but should focus on rural development, small enterprise promotion and self-employment.

Likewise, Acting Governor of the Nepal Rastra Bank, Dr. Neelam Dhungana Timsina praised the role played by microfinance in a country where about 21 per cent of the population is out of the access to formal financing options.

According to her, even though the government has brought various programmes for inclusive development, desired success has not been achieved, and it was the microfinance that supported in the drive.

Expressing concerns over the recent problems in the MFIs, Dhungana suggested that everyone should work responsibly to prevent the situation from worsening. Problem has aggravated with the current 6 per cent non-performing loans.



PHOTO: TRN
Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat instructing hydro promoters at a workshop on 'Hydropower Insurance Policy and Perspective' organised by Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN).

In the programme, the chairman of the organizing committee, Shankar Man Shrestha, said that the recent problems in microfinance are the weaknesses of the MFIs. They began to act like a profit making company and try to increase profits to distribute dividend. As a result, this sector was flooded with profit-seeking investors, Shrestha said and added that it was a big mistake not to make members of microfinance as shareholders.

"There was negligence even while disbursing the loan, the government opened license anew and there was even more distortion and deviation along with unhealthy competition. Companies were competing in luring the investors and interest rates were treated as a tool for profit."

Ram Bahadur Yadav, President of Nepal Microfinance Backers Association, complained that the government has neglected the microfinance sector which is promoting investment and enterprise along with financial awareness in the villages through nearly 6 million members.

Power projects should be insured in line with open policy

Meanwhile, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat instructed to shift the insurance policy of hydropower projects to non-tariff realm.

Speaking at a workshop on 'Hydropower Insurance Policy and Perspective' organised by Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN) in collaboration with Aone Reinsurance Broker Company Friday, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that hydropower projects should be insured in accordance with the open market policy.

He said that the tariff system applied in the insurance of hydropower projects should be removed and the insurance amount should be determined independently at the market-based price."

"This wrong practice of tariff and non-tariff insurance has happened. Leave the market free. Go to the market rate. Go based on what the real risk is. It is not justified to pay a lot even for a small risk," said Dr. Mahat.

Mahat said that the real risk should be studied and the insurance premium should be determined accordingly.

He said that insurance will be taken to transfer the risk, and emphasised that everyone should not face problems at once and that the company which faced the problem should be returned on time.

He said that it was sad that the flood-damaged projects did not receive payments even for nine months, and urged the insurance companies to settle the claims timely.

Dr. Mahat expressed happiness that the hydropower entrepreneurs who entered the sector when the private sector was opened up after 2046 B.S. are now constructing big hydropower projects.

Stating that the government is discussing to facilitate the issue of forest and environment, he said, "Due to migration, the forest has increased. The old way of planting as many trees as cut down is not correct in the current situation. Now, the forest area has increased from 45 per cent to 47 per cent."

He said that a decision will be taken after a comprehensive discussion in the upcoming budget regarding VAT exemption on machinery and equipment.

IPPAN president Ganesh Karki has said that the Nepali insurance companies have not been able to pay the claims on time to the hydropower projects.

According to him, the insurance companies have not paid the claims of Rs. 7 billion to the hydropower projects even though the Finance Minister directed to clear the claims of hydropower projects within a month.

He said that insurance of hydroelectric power was easy because there was no tariff rate in the insurance policy, but now many projects have not been insured after the Nepal Insurance Authority has imposed tariff rates.

Karki said that the tariff rate should be opened and if only Nepali companies cannot afford it, foreign companies should also be brought into the business.

He said, "An investment of Rs. 4,600 billion is required to produce 28,500 megawatts by 2035. I don't think that only Nepali companies can insure Rs. 4,600 billion. Let's open the tariff rate and invite foreign companies too."

POULTRY FIRM PRODUCING 23,000 EGGS DAILY, GIVING EMPLOYMENT TO 23 PEOPLE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Urlabari, Feb. 17

A poultry firm with the capacity of growing 35,000 layer chickens has come into operation in Kanepokhari Rural Municipality-3, Harakpur of Morang.

Drona Ghimire of Itahri and Padam Timalsina of Sundarharaincha have brought the firm namely - Harakpur Agriculture Private Limited - into operation with the investment of Rs. 70 million. Out of 35,000 chickens, about 23,000 chickens are producing eggs daily.

The firm spread over three bighas of land has given direct employment to 23 local people, said Ghimire, director of the firm. He said, "It has been three years since the firm started. However, the company, which was swamped by bird flu in the first year, is giving satisfactory production from last year."

Ghimire said that the firm, which incurred a loss of Rs. 13.3 million in the first year, has been managing its expenses for the last two years. In the firm, seven modern and well-equipped cages have been constructed, keeping chickens to produce eggs in two stages.

In order to ensure continuous production, when 23,100 chickens stop laying eggs, the remaining chicks are expected to become adults and start laying eggs. For the first five months, chicks should be grown only with feed. After that, they continuously produce eggs for 24-25 months.

Young people from the local Santhal community who go to work in agricultural farms in Haryana and Punjab in India are happy to find work in their villages. Ghimire said that if there is no outbreak of diseases like bird flu and pneumonia, other common diseases will be treated by local animal and bird health workers.

The third largest Harakpur Agriculture Firm of Koshi Province has started preparations to start the commercial rearing of goats along with chickens. Ghimire said that if there are two types of agricultural industries, one can make losses but the other can make profits.

The chicken manure has also increased agricultural production. According to him, commercial agriculture farmers are buying a sack of chicken manure for Rs. 300. On an average, 300 sacks of chicken dung are produced every week.

AMAZON CLAIMS 'NATIONAL LABOR BOARD' UNCONSTITUTIONAL

AP
New York, Feb. 17

Amazon is arguing in a legal filing that the 88-year-old National Labor Relations Board is unconstitutional, echoing similar arguments made this year by Elon Musk's SpaceX and the grocery store chain Trader Joe's in disputes about workers' rights and organizing.

The Amazon filing, made Thursday, came in response to a case before an administrative law judge overseeing a complaint from agency prosecutors who allege the company unlawfully retaliated against workers at a New York City warehouse who voted to unionize nearly two years ago.

In its filing, Amazon denies many of the charges and asks for the complaint to be dismissed. The company's attorneys then go further, arguing that the structure of the agency — particularly limits on the removal of administrative law judges and five board members appointed by the president — violates the separation of powers and infringes on executive powers stipulated in the Constitution.

The attorneys also argue that NLRB proceedings deny the company a trial by a jury and violate its due-process rights under the Fifth Amendment. An NLRB spokesperson declined to comment on the filing. Amazon did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

Nigeria's currency fallen to a record low

AP
Nigeria, Feb. 17

Nigerians are facing one of the West African nation's worst economic crises in years triggered by surging inflation, the result of monetary policies that have pushed the currency to an all-time low against the dollar. The situation has provoked anger and protests across the country.

The latest government statistics released Thursday showed the inflation rate in January rose to 29.9%, its highest since 1996, mainly driven by food and non-alcoholic beverages. Nigeria's currency, the naira, further plummeted to 1,524 to $1 on Friday, reflecting a 230% loss of value in the last year.

"My family is now living one day at a time (and) trusting God," said trader Idris Ahmed, whose sales at a clothing store in Nigeria's capital of Abuja have declined from an average of $46 daily to $16.

The plummeting currency worsens an already bad situation, further eroding incomes and savings. It squeezes millions of Nigerians already struggling with hardship due to government reforms including the removal of gas subsidies that resulted in gas prices tripling.



FILE PHOTO: AP
Market in Lagos, Nigeria. Nigerians are facing one of the worst economic crises in Africa as many years triggered by a surging inflation. Monetary policy had dipped the local currency to an all-time low against the dollar, provoking anger and protests across the country.

A snapshot of Nigeria's economy

With a population of more than 210 million people, Nigeria is not just Africa's most populous country but also the continent's largest economy. Its gross domestic product is driven mainly by services such as information technology and banking, followed by manufacturing and processing businesses and then agriculture.

The challenge is that the economy is far from sufficient for Nigeria's booming population, relying heavily on imports to meet the daily needs of its citizens from cars to cutlery. So it is easily affected by external shocks such as the parallel foreign exchange market that determines the price of goods and services.

Nigeria's economy is heavily dependent on crude oil, its largest foreign exchange earner. When crude prices plunged in 2014, authorities used its scarce foreign reserves to try to stabilize the naira amid multiple exchange rates. The government also shut down the land borders to encourage local production and limited access to the dollar for importers of certain items.

The measures, however, further destabilized the naira by facilitating a booming parallel market for the dollar. Crude oil sales that boost foreign exchange earnings have also dropped because of chronic theft and pipeline vandalism.

Monetary reforms poorly implemented

Shortly after taking the reins of power in May last year, President Bola Tinubu took bold steps to fix the ailing economy and attract investors. He announced the end of costly decade-slong gas subsidies, which the government said were no longer sustainable. Meanwhile, the country's multiple exchange rates were unified to allow market forces to determine the rate of the local naira against the dollar, which in effect devalued the currency.

Analysts say there were no adequate measures to contain the shocks that were bound to come as a result of reforms including the provision of a subsidized transportation system and an immediate increase in wages.

Nevada issues first license to a lounge in Las Vegas where cannabis can be consumed

AP
Las Vegas, Feb. 17

Nevada regulators have issued the first license to operate a lounge where cannabis can be consumed recreationally, marking the first of what are expected to be dozens of such operations.

The state Cannabis Compliance Board announced Thursday that the license was awarded to a business in Las Vegas following an inspection by agents earlier this week. The lounge — dubbed Smoke and Mirrors — is owned by Thrive Cannabis Marketplace, the state's largest independently owned cannabis business.

There are currently 19 lounges that have been approved by the compliance board for a conditional license. A final inspection will be required before a license is granted and they can open to the public.

It's been years since Nevada voters first approved legalizing recreational cannabis. In 2021, lawmakers cleared the way for business owners to apply for licenses to establish on-site consumption lounges. The state's cannabis industry had promoted the lounges for their economic development potential and pitched them as a draw for tourists who visit Las Vegas annually but can't legally use the products in places like hotels.

> There are currently 19 lounges that have been approved by the compliance board for a conditional license. A final inspection will be required before a license is granted and they can open to the public.

Thrive Cannabis Marketplace officials said their consumption lounge will open to the public in late February. It will have a range of products for customers — including cannabis-infused cocktails — and will serve as a hub for artists and musicians to showcase their work.

"It's more than a venue, it's a platform for the cannabis industry as a whole, where tourists and locals alike can be a part of a new chapter in the evolution of hospitality," said Chris LaPorte, managing partner of RESET, a Las Vegas-based cannabis hospitality company.

Algeria's black market for foreign currency underlines its economic woes

AP
Algeria, Feb. 17

In a square near the center of Algiers, currency traders carry wads of euros, pounds and dollars, hoping to exchange them to those worried about the plummeting value of the Algerian dinar.

This black market for foreign currencies is among the signs of the economic woes plaguing Algeria. The state, reluctant to allow the exchange rate to adjust fully, has proven incapable of limiting demand among the population as confidence in the dinar remains low.

The widening parallel exchange rate underscores how everyday Algerians have lost buying power as the government has juggled competing priorities, trying to combat inflation and maintain state spending, subsidies and price controls that keep people afloat.

In the oil-rich North African nation, business owners are rumored to be dumping their assets and scrounging up euros on the black market so their wealth isn't stuck. Middle-class people also rely on euros and dollars to buy things in short supply like medicine, vehicle parts or certain foods.

Last week, the official exchange rate allowed one euro to be sold for 145 Algerian dinar, while on the same day, currency traders were selling one euro for nearly 241 dinars on the black market — 66% higher than the official exchange rate.

Rabah Belamane, a 72-year-old retired teacher from Algiers, told The Associated Press that the official rate is a fiction and that his pension doesn't go as far as it used to in either dinar or euro. "The real value of the dinar is on the informal market, not in the bank, which uses an artificial rate to lie to the public," Belamane said.

Algeria has long been known for having among the region's most closed economies. It limits the amount of foreign currency its citizens can access to a modest tourism allowance that amounts to less than needed to carry out one of Islam's pilgrimages to Mecca or visit family in Europe's large Algerian diaspora.

The government estimates roughly $7 billion worth of foreign currency trades hands on the country's black market. From Lebanon to Nigeria, experts warn that having two parallel exchange rates can distort a country's economy, discourage investment and encourage corruption. Algeria has historically been reluctant to lower the official value of the dinar, worried that devaluation will spike prices and anger the population.

Traders are intimately aware that the gap between the official and black market exchange rate can narrow or widen by the day. They expect it to swing up as Ramadan approaches. "In recent days, the supply of euros has been lacking, which explains how it has shot up," trader Nourdine Sadaoui told the AP as he took a pause from yelling "Change!" at people passing by.

That shortage may make purchasing certain goods difficult for Algerians. But some in government believe it reflects the success of import restrictions and laws limiting how many euros can be brought into the country.

TRUMP AVOIDS 'CORPORATE DEATH PENALTY'

AP
New York, Feb. 17

Donald Trump won't face the corporate death penalty after all. A New York judge on Friday spared the ex-president that worst case punishment as he ruled in a civil case alleging Trump fraudulently misrepresented financial figures to get cheaper loans and other benefits.

Still, Trump got slammed hard, facing big cash penalties, outside supervision of his companies and restrictions on his borrowing. In a pretrial ruling last year, the same judge threatened to shut down much of the Republican presidential front-runner's business by calling for the "dissolution" of corporate entities that hold many of his marquee properties.

'EC working to secure voting rights for Nepalis living abroad'

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) **Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya** has said that efforts are being made through diplomatic channels with relevant countries to secure voting rights for Nepali citizens living abroad. *The Rising Nepal's* **Indira Aryal** had a conversation on the electoral system of the country and other issues. Excerpts:

After the promulgation of the Constitution of Nepal, elections at all three levels have been conducted twice. What achievements have been made so far? How satisfied is the commission with its role and the electoral outcome?

Thapaliya: The establishment of a federal democratic republican system has been crucial in the implementation of the federal republic. The government at all three levels, empowered by the sovereign people, is now represented by around 42,000 elected representatives. There is a growing belief that elections can be conducted in a clean, free, impartial, and cost-effective manner.

The involvement and cooperation of the communication circle, political parties, voters, and all stakeholders have initiated a chain of collaboration and cooperation in election management expenditures. It has been proven that efficiency can be achieved in election management expenses. Based on past experiences, efforts have been made to control and manage elections, which have become more transparent and cost-effective.

While satisfaction is in question, based on the experience of two successive periodic elections and the experiences gained from National Assembly members election and by-elections, it is necessary to move forward amending the election laws, addressing the subject matter, and harmonising all structures of the commission up to the district level to expand coordination to all local levels and minimise discrepancies. Actions such as extending support and overcoming setbacks have made the commission more serious. Despite the lack of resources, progress in improvement has not been achieved at the desired pace. It is necessary to focus on technological advancement, election education, capacity building, structural improvements, and other related areas before the election. Extensive improvements and a positive outlook are necessary in the areas of development, election education, capacity building, and structural improvement, among others, during the pre-election period.

Would you like to elucidate further on this?

Thapaliya: In principle, the commission is an independent, autonomous, and empowered constitutional body in the context of election management. However, in practice, there are many challenges. Some provisions related to elections under election laws and certain provisions of the Constitution of Nepal Amendment Act, as well as the Political Parties Act 2073, particularly section 32(2) regarding the division of political parties, were amended. The commission was unaware of this. When there is no consultation in Parliament, and immediate action is necessary, it should come on the recommendation of the Council of Ministers. Matters such as party division, which are related to internal party affairs, become difficult for the government to handle, and it becomes necessary to act promptly. The amendment was repealed, but the original provision was not reinstated. Since then, for the past two and a half years, it has been inactive. How will the commission be accountable and manage responsibility in this regard? If the law made by the Parliament is to be implemented by the government, how can legislative supremacy be maintained in lawmaking?

INTERVIEW

Why does the Election Commission need authority to announce election dates?

Thapaliya: The subject of announcing election dates always becomes controversial. Voters are sovereign. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights of 1948, our Constitution, and the Election Act all establish the secrecy of elections and the system where voters independently vote for their chosen candidates. The exercise of this right to choose and be chosen is crucial. During the recent national assembly elections, it was observed that voters had crossed the floor, and voted across parties, which led to the creation of misleading statements and information through expressions and news. The practice of using the term "floor-crossing" in the context of elections and parliamentary practices has been sought to be used in a single meaning. Exploring how to use floor-crossing in the context of secret balloting in elections and parliamentary practices raises questions about how voter confidentiality is maintained. On this subject, through the media, I am making a special request to advocate for the universal rights of voters.

What initiatives have been taken to improve gender representation in the upcoming elections?

Thapaliya: This is the main topic. We have presented a draft of an integrated election law amendment to the Government of Nepal, which addresses all these issues. This proposal includes the Election Management Bill. We believe that within a year, the bill will be passed, and preparations for the upcoming elections can be conducted by the same law. In addition to this, by using existing laws, we are working on decentralising voter registration and updating the voter list through local authorities, registering overseas Nepali voters through diplomatic missions, conducting election education through local authorities, and improving the voter list through an electoral system. We are advancing these tasks.



CEC Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya

Let's change the topic. The participation of voters in elections has decreased, and the invalid votes remain the same. Is it not the responsibility of the commission to address these?

Thapaliya: Certainly, it is. We are serious about this. We are actively seeking solutions and strategies. However, it is not solely the fault of the commission. There are many seen and unseen reasons behind it. The first thing we noticed after the promulgation of Nepal's constitution was the unique perspective of political parties towards the system we relied on. Due to the mentality of winning elections and joining the government, some leaders, activists, and members of certain parties directed their decision-making towards nominating candidates and issuing directives to vote for a specific party symbol rather than allowing their principled activists to nominate candidates and issue directives to vote for a particular party symbol. This undermined the democratic system based on multi-party competition established by Nepal's constitution. The use of individuals rather than party ideology, principles, and programmes in elections under a multi-party system has weakened the sentiment and enthusiasm of ordinary voters.

Secondly, with about 4 million citizens studying, working, doing business, or seeking foreign employment abroad, there is a lack of legal provisions to facilitate their voting rights while residing overseas. On the other hand, political parties and candidates have not been able to attract and motivate them to return to the country to cast their votes during elections. Even local voters who remain within the country are not enthusiastic about going to their local polling centres to vote. The legal framework for voting from where they are currently located has become legally complex. We expect that future laws will seek appropriate solutions to this issue. We have proposed solutions to address this burning issue.

Thirdly, the Election Commission's policy of deploying voter education through local authorities to reach every household has not been successful. Fourthly, despite the complexity of ballot papers and the honorable Supreme Court's orders, due to the lack of legal provisions, the provision for NO VOTE (None Of The Above) could not be implemented, leading to an increase in invalid votes. Fifthly, voter turnout in parliamentary and provincial elections is about ten per cent lower than in local elections. Although a comprehensive study has not been conducted on this matter, from observations, it seems that while MPs are responsible for legislation, policy-making, and lawmaking, their focus often diverges to individual projects like roads, water supply, bridges, irrigation, employment, agriculture, development, tourism promotion, etc., rather than fulfilling their core responsibilities. This diversion has led to a decrease in voter attraction and thus participation. Therefore, the real responsibility of lawmakers needs to be clarified, not only through voter education but also by ensuring similar conduct from candidates.

Some candidates themselves claim that our electoral system is expensive and only those with money, not honest individuals, can afford to run for elections. How has the Election Commission confronted this issue?

Thapaliya: This question has been raised repeatedly, even in parliamentary committees. To find the answer to this, we need to explore some questions. For example, in a multi-party competitive democratic system, does a person vote for the ideology, principles, and programmes of a party, or for the charisma and status of an individual? Is it really expensive to promote a party's ideology, principles, programmes, and election symbols? Is the vote of an empowered voter truly a commodity that can be bought and sold? Should party officials, members, and activists receive additional benefits when they engage in election-related activities?

The Election Commission has rightly pointed out that the expenditure limit set for campaigning under the Election Code of Conduct is insufficient. What should be the standard for determining whether an election system is cheap or expensive? Can the system punish actions contrary to election laws, codes of conduct, and unethical practices, regardless of whether they are committed by candidates or parties? Through analyzing such questions, the Commission has clearly stated that it is not about the position, money, influence, or temptation, but about winning through thought, principles, integrity, and honesty. The Commission has stated that all candidates within the prescribed limit should disclose their expenses and present accurate details, and it is not the ethical right of any candidate to claim that the election has become expensive.

Political parties should reach a consensus to determine how to improve our system. Individuals who defy the system and laws they themselves have created cannot be expected to uphold governance and prosperity. Despite these challenges, the Commission is seeking appropriate addressing of potential problems in the proposed law. Efforts are being made to amend political party-related laws to further regulate them. We are not only concerned about this issue but also sensitive to it.

You have raised the issue of voting rights for Nepalis living abroad. When will their voting rights be ensured?

Thapaliya: The current election laws do not grant the right to vote from abroad to Nepalis living overseas. However, in the proposed Election Management Bill, fundamental voting rights are expected to be granted to those who can register as voters, allowing them to vote in Nepal or participate in advance voting. The possibility of online voting is also being considered after studying its security and feasibility.

Efforts are being made through diplomatic initiatives with relevant countries to secure voting rights for Nepali citizens living abroad. While the concept may seem simple, its implementation is not as straightforward. Once the new laws are specified, procedures for registering voters' lists for Nepali residing abroad will be approved, and preparations are underway under the coordination of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Government of Nepal to begin voter registration processes in coordination with some countries.

Nepal has also initiated discussions on the electoral system it has adopted. What steps has the Commission taken in this regard?

Thapaliya: Primarily, the Election Commission is the constitutional body mandated to manage elections under the rights provided by the Constitution and laws according to the electoral system adopted by the country. However, the laws related to political parties also assign the responsibility to the Commission to conduct discussions and research on the electoral system. Accordingly, the Commission has conducted an extensive study on the subject of the electoral system through policy research institutions. Although the study report has not been received yet, discussions and presentations primarily focus on the following topics related to the electoral system.

Local govt provides uniforms to the students in Kalikot



Photo: TRN

Mahendra Bahadur Shahi, Deputy Mayor, Tilagufa Municipality, with students after they distributed uniforms to students in classes 1 to 5. The municipality allocated a sum of Rs. 39,000 for the students, acknowledging the geographical challenges faced by the school.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kalikot, Feb. 17

Tilagufa Municipality in Kalikot district is actively supporting students enrolled at Dargam Community School. The municipality has extended its assistance by providing uniforms to a community school situated in Ward No. 9 of the municipality.

Mahendra Bahadur Shahi, Deputy Mayor, upon his visit to the school last Friday, distributed uniforms to students in classes 1 to 5 attending Satyanarayan Basic School. The municipality allocated a sum of Rs. 39,000 for the students, acknowledging the geographical challenges faced by the school, and emphasising that even a simple uniform can pose a financial burden.

Shahi highlighted the municipality's commitment to understanding and addressing the challenges faced by remote schools. He mentioned that, in the past, some schools received uniforms with the assistance of the locals. The local government representatives are dedicated to comprehending the issues of schools operating amid resource shortages, ensuring continued support for students in remote areas.

Meghe Katuwal, Chairman of the School Management Committee, expressed gratitude for the municipality's recognition of the challenges faced by students in remote schools. Katuwal emphasised that this support instills confidence among students, assuring them that the government cares for them. School Principal Kul Khatri echoed these sentiments, stating that the financial burden on parents has been alleviated with the assistance of the municipality. He emphasised that any form of government support, whether small or large, serves as a positive encouragement for everyone involved.

PROGRAMME LAUNCHED TO CONNECT HUMLA WITH HALESI

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Feb. 17

A programme has been initiated to connect Namkha Rural Municipality in Humla and Halesi Tuwachung Municipality in Khotang District. The objective behind this initiative is to foster cultural relations, and a dedicated programme was organised between the two localities to formalise their partnership.

Prem Bahadur Lama, the Ward Chairman of Namkha Rural Municipality, highlighted the diverse religious, tourist, and cultural heritage of Namkha Rural Municipality. Likewise, Halesi Tuwachung Municipality boasts the renowned tri-religious sites Halesi and Kirat Tuwachung Zayzum, situated near the historic location of Kailash Mansarovar.

Chairman Lama and Halesi Tuwachung Municipality Mayor Bimala Rai have successfully signed a partnership agreement between Namkha Rural Municipality and Tuwachung Municipality. The proposal was put forth by Chairman Lama and was graciously accepted by Mayor Rai. Subsequently, President Lama's team travelled from Humla to Khotang to formalise this partnership.

Chairman Lama expressed the commitment to promote religious and tourist activities by establishing cultural ties between the two localities. He emphasized that this partnership would not only contribute to cultural aspects but also lead to strengthening mutual relations between Namkha Rural Municipality and Halesi Tuwachung Municipality. The Chairman further elaborated that the connection facilitated by Miteri Sino would pave the way for developing and promoting religious and tourist areas in both localities.

Bajhang people face water crisis after quake

BY SAILENDRA ROKAYA
Bajhang, Feb. 17

Following the earthquake, the amount of water in drinking fountains has decreased, leading locals to endure long queues to fill their pitchers. The villages in the municipality, scattered at the foot of the hill and on the plateau, historically established homes near water sources.

Durgathali Rural Municipality, located in the remote area of the district, is facing a significant water crisis as most of its water sources started drying up after an earthquake with its epicentre at Chainpur, on October 3.

Following the earthquake, the amount of water in drinking fountains has decreased, leading locals to endure long queues to fill their pitchers.

The villages in the municipality, scattered at the foot of the hill and on the plateau, historically established homes near water sources. However, these sources are now depleting, causing a pressing issue for drinking water in the region.

Dil Bahadur Thapa, the chairman of Durgathali Rural Municipality, noted that the problem has escalated since the earthquake, affecting the water source that was previously tapped from a distant spring. Thapa emphasized that the water supply issue within the municipality has become more complex.

In Thapagaon, an introduced water supply scheme is grappling with challenges a year after its inception. Even the village spring has dried up, causing a shortage of drinking water in Thapagaon. Uttam Thapa, a resident, expressed concerns over the dwindling water supply, citing the drying up of traditional water sources like stone taps near the village. Waiting in long queues for water has become a daily struggle for the locals.

The water supply problem extends to other villages in Durgathali Rural Municipality, impacting more than five springs, including Maulali drinking water supply, Anzada water supply, Waligaon water supply, and Jafri water supply. Residents attribute the drying up of these springs to weakened ground conditions resulting from the earthquake.

Similar challenges are observed in other municipalities of the district, with traditional water sources like streams and wells drying out. Locals in various areas, such as Talkot and Khiratadi, report sudden drying up of vital water sources, causing inconvenience to communities.

The destruction of forests, landslides and haphazard construction are seen as contributing factors to the drying out of water sources. The diminishing water sources impact not only daily life but also cultural practices, as traditional water wells and stone streams are disappearing, affecting rituals performed by the villagers.

Despite the severity of the situation, there appears to be limited initiative in safeguarding and preserving these traditional water sources in the village, which has led to the drying up of wells and streams in over 50 villages, according to unofficial reports.

The community is grappling with the consequences, and urgent measures are needed to address this growing water crisis.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The man who is swimming against the stream knows the strength of it.
- Woodrow Wilson

EDITORIAL

Risking Lives For Money

Nepal indeed has a long history of contributing troops to United Nations peacekeeping missions. The Gurkhas, in particular, have gained a reputation for their bravery and professionalism in military operations around the world. Nepal's involvement in conflicts such as supporting the British during the Sepoy Mutiny and participating in both World Wars can be seen in the context of historical alliances and diplomatic relationships. During the time of the Rana regime in Nepal, there were strategic and diplomatic considerations in aligning with the British Empire. However, the Nepali youths joining the Russian Army out of desperation and frustration, caused by widespread unemployment, is now a vexing issue, exposing socio-economic hardships Nepalis have been facing. Unemployment and limited opportunities have forced Nepali youths to work in dangerous conditions.

As per official figures, 14 Nepali youths have been killed while fighting from the Russian side in the Russia-Ukraine war. Although there are no official reports, it is believed that about 1,500 Nepali youths have been engaged in fight against Ukraine. Families back home have made every possible request to the government to rescue their loved ones serving on the front line of the vicious conflict but our diplomatic efforts to rescue our youths does not seem enough. The families of Nepali youths slain in the military conflict have demanded the repatriation of the dead bodies of their kin so that they can perform their funeral rites. Considering the gravity of the matter, the Nepali embassy in Moscow is doing its best for the repatriation of the Nepali youths working as mercenaries.

As per news reports, each family of the deceased youth will receive Rs. 15 million in compensation and Rs. 7.3 million if the one that got killed had no insurance. The Russian government has agreed to pay compensation through the Nepali Embassy in Moscow. The Russian government has taken responsibility for providing compensation to the families of the youths killed. It is necessary to discourage foreign youths from joining in risky battle. Families of Nepalis recruited in the Russian 'special military operation' have persistently urged the government to take diplomatic initiatives for the repatriation of their loved ones as more reports of Nepali youths getting killed in the frontline continue to pour in.

Such a situation highlights the importance of addressing issues such as unemployment, poverty, and economic backwardness in Nepal to provide better prospects for its citizens and reduce the need for such drastic measures to support the family. It also underscores the importance of international cooperation and support in helping countries like Nepal to address their socioeconomic challenges. It might sound harsh but it's a grim reality that labour has become the main export of Nepal. The economy of the country is highly dependent on remittance. Youths battered by unemployment are paying huge sums to manpower agents to get recruited in the Russian Army. Nepal Police on December 5 arrested 10 people on charge of luring the Nepali youths into the Russian force. We should retain our youths by creating job opportunities so that our labour force can constructively contribute to the economic development and they are not compelled to join as mercenaries in foreign armed forces.

Vive La Democracy

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

Some people of this country still believe that the terms monarchy and democracy are interchangeable. It is because of their age-old religious inclination to the kingship. Monarchy, which they consider an incarnation of Almighty God Bishnu, is the product of feudal society. Resorting to the old mindset, the monarch keeps himself high above common people, making his fiats as the law of the land. This does not fit with the modern-day sovereign citizens. So, accepting a monarch amounts to turning the clocks back.

Democracy, on the other hand, is a political system based on rule by the consent of the governed people. We practice the representative democracy which is exercised via free and fair elections of all levels. Democracy protects the rights of minority, guarantees the rule of law and human rights, among other things. Nepali people have fought for democracy time and again. Their struggles spanned over seven decades before establishing the federal democratic republic.

Nepalis had first waged armed revolt to overthrow the Rana Oligarchy. The nation plunged into autocratic rule 10 years after the 104-year-old Rana regime was toppled. King Mahendra imposed Pachayat system that was equally despotic and unilateral in handling the affairs of the state. In the period of monarchy, the Nepali people used to live in the constant fear of being arrested, punished and even murdered. The cops in plain clothes used to roam in the villages. This scribe still recalls atrocities carried out by Panchas and Mandales. Petrified by their terrorising acts, our parents used to warn us, "Do not speak loudly, even the walls of the house have ears. If Panchas hear something bad on monarchy from you, they will take you away."

So, the freedom-loving people gathered courage and began peaceful movement named Satyagraha in the 2042 BS. Though the forgetful Nepali people have soft corner for late king Birendra, many pro-democracy fighters and patriotic people were killed under his nose. Then, banned leftist political forces and Nepali Congress joined hands to end Panchayat system.

Amid political instabilities, the CPN-Maoist, a hard-liner communist group, started an insurgency to abolish monarchy. The Maoist and parliamentary parties came together to do away with the dictatorial rule in 2006. Finally, the Constituent Assembly decided to abolish a 240-year-old monarchy, converting Nepal into a democratic federal republic.

We are observing the 74th Democracy Day across the country tomorrow by organising various programmes. The political leaders from ruling and opposition will deliver customary speeches, calling for upholding value of democracy. As Jose Marti says, 'Like bone to the human body, and the axle to the wheel, and the song to a bird, and air to the wing, thus is liberty the essence of life. Whatever is done without it is imperfect.'

It is difficult to achieve a perfect form of democracy. We fought against Rana Oligarchy and Shah Dynasty for democracy. We are still ready to tame any force which stands in the way of democracy. We have only expectations that the leaders should work to strengthen democracy and speed up development works honestly. If they lose public faith and social dignity, the democracy will weaken.

Maoist Statute Convention

Adding Vigour To The Party

Ritu Raj Subedi



The ruling CPN-Maoist Centre has decided to form all committees through direct voting in its recently concluded statute convention, a move that is expected to check continuous decline of popularity of former rebels. Despite the reluctance of top leadership, the convention impelled it to exercise 'people's democracy' to pick 199 central committee members through its special general convention. However, the post of chairman and 11-member central office will be constituted by the elected CC members.

This is the first time the Maoist Centre opted for electing the CC member through the direct election. Maoist Centre chair Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda termed this as 'break in continuity'. However, this provision obliges him to get elected as CC member from the delegates, which might sound strange for the Maoist supremo, who has been taking on the mantle of leadership uninterruptedly for almost 38 years. With the amendment to the statute, the CC is expected to be filled with popular faces having a grip on the grassroots supporters. This might end the culture of cozying up to the party powerful cliques to move on higher echelon without popular backing.

Pertinent question

However, the pertinent question is: can the new provision give a new lease of life to the party that has been continuously losing election after the first Constituent Assembly (CA) elections held in 2008. The party emerged the largest political force, pushing the established Nepali Congress and CPN-UML to second and third position. The Maoists rose t o power through the ballots at a time when the world's communist movement had already lost its lustre. But the former rebels could not maintain this momentum in the subsequent elections. In the second CA polls conducted in 2013, the party shrunk to the distant third. In the general elections of 2022, the Maoist Centre had to compete with newly formed Rastriya Swotantra Party (RSP) for the third place.

Frustrated by waning strength of the party, some leaders and delegates even called for changing the party's name and poll symbol in the convention. Party deputy general secretary Janardan Sharma proposed removing the term 'Maoist' in its nomenclature and adopting 'socialism' in its place so as to check the continuous loss in the urban areas. Although Sharma's motion was rejected by the delegates, this implies the growing defeatist mentality affecting the party functionaries. The word 'Maoism' is the party's identity and prestige. Its removal from the party name also poses a question to the relevance of the Maoist movement.

However, it is misconception to assume that the phrase 'Maoism' drove the voters away from the party. It is the conduct and deeds of its leaders that have made the people disenchanted with the party. Otherwise, it could not clinch a sensational victory in the first CA elections under the same appellation. Failure to respect and utilise that huge mandate forced the party to reel from incessant defeats. The factional infighting caused a series of party divisions, disrupting the organisation from top to bottom. The leadership

> The statute convention's bid to democratise the party's wings is a drastic step in giving a fresh impetus to Maoists struggling to pick up the pieces.

penchant to stick to power through the compromises of any sort also frustrated its rank and file. Its flirtation with identity politics and indifference to the agenda of social and economic justice that it raised during the decade-long insurgency also alienated the middle and lower classes of society.

There may be ideological debate on the rationality of Maoist insurgency. Despite leading government three times and becoming its part several times, the Maoist Centre has been unable to give justice to the conflict victims. A large number of people, victimised by the state side, are waiting for justice and reparation but their hopes have been dashed repeatedly. Inordinate delay in completing the transitional justice process has let the conflict victims down, a reason that dented competency and credibility of the Maoist party in the masses.

There are other factors that have diluted Maoist party's impact in Nepali society. Sometime back, the Supreme Court (SC) rescinded the government's decision to grant public holiday on Fagun 1 to mark *Janayudhha Diwas* (People's War Day). On Fagun 1, 2052 B.S. (February 13, 1996), the then CPN-Maoist launched insurgency with the goal of ending constitutional monarchy and establishing people's republic. The apex court's verdict has ruffled many a feather in the Maoist party. In their decision, SC Justices – Dr. Aanandamohan Bhattarai and Mahesh Sharma Paudel – have analysed the term *'Janayuddha'*, based on the decision of Constitutional Committee of CA, new constitution and Comprehensive Peace Agreement (CPA). The Constitutional Committee had rejected the term *'Janayuddha'* with a majority when the Maoist Centre was the largest party in the CA.

Consensus

In the preamble of the constitution, the term 'armed struggle' has been used instead of *'Janayuddha'*, argue the Justice duo, adding that the CPA and laws related to Transitional Justice have not mentioned this word. The SC also sought national consensus among the conflict victims, political parties and concerned stakeholders in granting public holiday on Fagun 1. Its verdict came in a response to a writ of conflict victims, seeking to quash the government's decision to observe *Janayuddha Diwas*.

Now the Maoist movement stands at a crossroads. In his speech, PM Prachanda has called on Maoist splinter groups that believe in *Janayuddha Diwas* to come together to create a powerful block. However, Maoist factions are poles apart in terms of ideology and outlook on economic and foreign policy. So unity or alliance among them seems improbable in the foreseeable future. The statute convention's bid to democratise the party's wings is a drastic step in giving a fresh impetus to Maoists struggling to pick up the pieces.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)

Poor Diet Causes Sleep Disorder

Dr. Shyam P Lohani



In today's fast-paced world, it is not uncommon for individuals to prioritise work, social commitments, and entertainment over their sleep. As a result, sleep deprivation has become a prevalent issue, affecting millions of people worldwide. However, what many fail to realise is the significant impact that food habits can have on our sleep patterns. Sleep disorders have become a growing concern in recent years, affecting millions of individuals worldwide.

Sleep disorders encompass a wide range of conditions, including insomnia, sleep apnea, restless leg syndrome, and narcolepsy, among others. Epidemiological studies have revealed alarming statistics, indicating that sleep disorders affect a significant portion of the population. For instance, it is estimated that approximately 30 per cent of adults worldwide suffer from insomnia, while sleep apnea affects around 10-20 per cent of adults. These numbers highlight the urgent need for comprehensive research and public health initiatives to tackle this pervasive issue.

Risks

The impact of sleep disorders on overall well-being and quality of life cannot be underestimated. Sleep disorders not only affect individuals' health but also impose a significant socioeconomic burden on society. The economic costs associated with sleep disorders are substantial, including healthcare expenses, reduced work productivity, and increased accidents. Epidemiological research can help quantify these costs, providing policymakers with valuable data to allocate resources effectively and develop targeted interventions.

Understanding the risk factors associated with sleep disorders is crucial for prevention and intervention efforts. Epidemiological studies have identified several factors that contribute to the development of sleep disorders, including age, gender, obesity, smoking, alcohol consumption, and mental health conditions. Besides, all those factors, one of the most important factors is food habits. It is important to note that sleep disorders have been linked to a myriad of health consequences, such as cardiovascular diseases, diabetes, obesity, impaired cognitive function, and mental health disorders.

It is widely recognised that what we eat directly affects our physical health. However, the influence of diet on sleep patterns and quality is often overlooked. Studies have shown that certain foods, such as those high in sugar and caffeine, can disrupt sleep patterns and lead to insomnia. On the other hand, a diet rich in nutrients, vitamins, and minerals can promote better sleep quality and duration. Therefore, it is essential to adopt a balanced diet that supports both physical health and sleep hygiene.

The rise of fast food culture has undeniably contributed to unhealthy eating habits. Fast food chains offer quick and convenient meals that are often high in unhealthy fats, sugars, and processed ingredients. These foods, while satisfying in the short term, can wreak havoc on our sleep patterns. Studies have shown that consuming high-fat meals close to bedtime can lead to disrupted sleep, increased wakefulness, and decreased sleep quality.

Another major culprit behind sleep deprivation is excessive sugar consumption. Sugar-rich foods and beverages,

> By raising awareness, conducting robust research, and implementing evidence-based interventions, we can address the silent epidemic of sleep disorders

such as sodas, candies, and desserts, are not only addictive but can also interfere with our ability to fall asleep and maintain a deep sleep. The rapid spikes and crashes in blood sugar levels caused by consuming excessive sugar can disrupt our natural sleep-wake cycle, leaving us feeling restless and fatigued the next day.

Caffeine, a widely consumed stimulant, is known to keep us awake and alert. While a cup of coffee in the morning can help kick-start our day, consuming caffeine later in the day can significantly impact our sleep. Many individuals rely on caffeinated beverages like coffee, energy drinks, and sodas to combat daytime sleepiness caused by lack of sleep. However, this only perpetuates the cycle of sleep deprivation, as caffeine can stay in our system for hours, making it harder to fall asleep at night.

Late-night snacking has become a common habit for many individuals, often as a result of irregular eating patterns. Unfortunately, indulging in heavy meals or snacks close to bedtime can lead to digestive discomfort, heartburn, and disrupted sleep. Additionally, consuming large amounts of food before bed can cause fluctuations in blood sugar levels, leading to restless sleep and frequent awakenings. Recognising the detrimental impact of unhealthy food habits on sleep is the first step toward breaking the vicious cycle of sleep deprivation. Adopting a balanced diet that includes whole foods, fruits, vegetables, and lean proteins can promote better sleep quality. Avoiding excessive sugar, caffeine, and late-night snacking can also significantly improve sleep patterns.

Awareness

Despite the prevalence and impact of sleep disorders, they often go undiagnosed and untreated. Public awareness campaigns are essential to educate individuals about the importance of healthy sleep habits and the potential consequences of untreated sleep disorders. Furthermore, research should be prioritized to identify vulnerable populations, understand the underlying mechanisms, and develop evidence-based interventions. Collaboration between researchers, healthcare professionals, and policymakers is crucial to address this public health challenge effectively.

It is important to develop intervention strategies to mitigate the burden of sleep disorders. This may include early screening and diagnosis, promoting healthy sleep hygiene practices, improving access to treatment options, and integrating sleep health into public health policies. Additionally, interdisciplinary collaborations between epidemiologists, sleep specialists, psychologists, and other healthcare professionals can enhance the effectiveness of interventions.

The data on sleep disorders provides valuable insights into their prevalence, risk factors, and impact on public health. By raising awareness, conducting robust research, and implementing evidence-based interventions, we can address the silent epidemic of sleep disorders. It is time to prioritize sleep health as an integral part of public health agendas, ensuring a well-rested and healthier future for individuals and communities.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director of the Health Concern. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 18, 1974

Literacy Classes In Baglung

Baglung, Feb. 17: Another 27 literacy classes are running in Baglung district, it is learnt from the district education office, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Urgency Of Climate Fund



This is in reference to the news titled *"Nepal needs financial support to deal with climate crisis: PM"*. There is no doubt that the country urgently needs climate fund, also known as loss and damage fund, to adapt to the warming planet, and the affluent countries, which got rich by burning the fossil fuel that are responsible for the climate crisis, must pay global south, which, despite contributing nothing, are having to disproportionately deal with the crisis.

The affluent countries must generously contribute to the fund and end the injustice. With its mountains denuding of snow, mass displacement of highlanders, the risk of new types of disease making inroads into the settlements in higher altitude, as well as alarming increase in the frequency of extreme weather events, like catastrophic floods and heat wave, the country is overwhelmed by the magnitude of crisis.

The disbursement of the funds would be a small but crucial relief. Delaying it can be costly.

Kritagya Neupane
Pokhara

TAILPIECE

A man goes into the hospital for some tests. The medical staff knocks him out, and when he comes around there is a doctor peering over him, pulling up his eyelid and wielding the reflex hammer.

The doctor says: "Ah, I'm glad you're awake. I'm afraid I have some good news and some bad news."

The man says: "Don't hold back, Doc, tell me the bad news."

The doctor says "Your condition was worse than we thought and we had to amputate both of your legs."

The man asks: "What is the good news, then?"

The doctor replies: "The man in the next bed wants to buy your slippers."

Judge orders Trump to pay $355 million for civil fraud over false wealth claims

AP
New York, Feb. 17

A New York judge ordered Donald Trump on Friday to pay $355 million in penalties, finding that the former president lied about his wealth for years in a sweeping civil fraud verdict that pierces his billionaire image but stops short of putting his real estate empire out of business.

Judge Arthur Engoron's decision after a trial in New York Attorney General Letitia James' lawsuit punishes Trump, his company and executives, including his two eldest sons, for scheming to dupe banks, insurers and others by inflating his wealth on financial statements. It forces a shakeup at the top of his Trump Organization, putting the company under court supervision and curtailing how it does business.

The decision is a staggering setback for the Republican presidential front-runner, the latest and costliest consequence of his recent legal troubles. The magnitude of the verdict on top of penalties in other cases could dramatically dent Trump's financial resources and damage his identity as a savvy businessman who parlayed his fame as a real estate developer into reality TV stardom and the presidency. He has vowed to appeal and won't have to pay immediately.

Trump's true punishment could be far costlier because under state law he is also required to pay interest on the penalties, which James said puts him on the hook for more than $450 million. The amount, which would be paid to the state, will grow until he pays.

The judge made clear, however, that the Trump Organization will continue to operate, backing away from an earlier ruling that would have dissolved Trump's companies.



PHOTO: AP

Republican presidential candidate former President Donald Trump speaks at his Mar-a-Lago estate, Friday, Feb. 16, 2024, in Palm Beach, Fla.

Engoron, a Democrat, concluded that Trump and his company were "likely to continue their fraudulent ways" without the penalties and controls he imposed. Engoron concluded that Trump and his co-defendants "failed to accept responsibility" and that experts who testified on his behalf "simply denied reality."

"This is a venial sin, not a mortal sin," Engoron wrote in a searing 92-page opinion. "They did not rob a bank at gunpoint. Donald Trump is not Bernard Madoff. Yet, defendants are incapable of admitting the error of their ways."

He said their "complete lack of contrition and remorse borders on pathological" and "the frauds found here leap off the page and shock the conscience."

Trump said the decision was "election inference" and "weaponization against a political opponent," complaining to reporters at his Mar-a-Lago estate in Florida that he was being penalised for "having built a perfect company, great cash, great buildings, great everything."

James, a Democrat, told reporters "justice has been served" and called the ruling "a tremendous victory for this state, this nation, and for everyone who believes that we all must play by the same rules — even former presidents."

"Now, Donald Trump is finally facing accountability for his lying, cheating, and staggering fraud. Because no matter how big, rich or powerful you think you are, no one is above the law," James said.

Trump still owns the Trump Organization, but he put his assets into a revocable trust and relinquished a leadership role when he became president in 2017, putting his sons Eric and Donald Trump Jr. in charge of day-to-day operations. Engoron's ruling imposes a three-year ban on Trump serving as an officer or director of any New York company and bars his sons for two years, effectively requiring the company to find new leadership, at least temporarily.

The monetary penalties involve what Engoron said were "ill-gotten gains" that Trump attained by making himself seem richer. They include money Trump saved by securing lower loan interest rates and profits from the sale of properties that he might not have been able to develop without that financing.

Eric and Donald Trump Jr. were each ordered to pay $4 million, their share of profits from the 2022 sale of Trump's Washington, D.C. hotel, and the company's former longtime chief financial officer Allen Weisselberg was ordered to pay $1 million — half of the $2 million severance he's receiving. All told, Trump and his co-defendants owe $364 million, which James' office said grows to $464 million when interest is included. Weisselberg and another longtime company executive, Jeffrey McConney, were barred from ever holding a corporate finance or leadership role in the state.

Engoron put the Trump Organization under the supervision of a independent monitor for at least three years, extending oversight he ordered after James sued Trump in 2022, and said the company must hire an independent compliance director to ensure that it follows financial reporting obligations and rules.

Engoron wrote that stripping Trump of his companies, as he'd previously ordered, was no longer necessary because the company will be under a "two-tiered oversight" with the independent monitor, retired federal judge Barbara Jones, and the compliance director keeping an eye on any activities that could lead to fraud.

Because it was civil, not criminal, the case did not carry the potential of prison time.

Japan's new flagship H3 rocket achieves planned trajectory

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 17

A Japanese flagship H3 rocket lifted off from a space station in southwestern Japan Saturday, successfully achieving its planned trajectory and releasing two small observation satellites in a key second test, overcoming its failed debut launch a year ago and buoying hope for the country to be competitive in the global space race.

The H3 rocket blasted off from a launch pad at the Tanegashima Space Center on time Saturday morning, two days after its originally scheduled liftoff was delayed due to bad weather.

The rocket successfully achieved the planned trajectory and released the two satellites, the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency, or JAXA, said.

"We feel so relieved to be able to announce the good results," JAXA President Hiroshi Yamakawa told a news conference.

H3's main missions are to secure independent access to space and to acquire global competitiveness amid growing international demand for satellite launches. "We made a big first step today toward achieving that goal," Yamakawa said.

Saturday's success is a boost for Japan's space program following a recent streak of successes, including a historic precision touchdown on the Moon of an unmanned spacecraft last month.

Saturday's launch was closely watched as a test for Japan's space development after H3 failed in its debut flight last March. JAXA and its main contractor Mitsubishi Heavy Industries have been developing H3 as a successor to its current mainstay, H-2A, which is set to retire after two more flights.

As the rocket soared and released its first payload successfully, project members at the JAXA command center cheered and hugged each other in a livestreaming footage. NHK television said some staff at a press center were seen crying with relief and joy.



PHOTO: AP

An H3 rocket lifts off at Tanegashima Space Center in Kagoshima, southern Japan Saturday, Feb. 17, 2024.

JAXA H3 project manager Masashi Okada called the result "perfect," saying H3 cleared all missions set for Saturday's flight.

"I now feel a heavy load taken off my shoulders. But now is the real start for H3, and we will work to steadily improve it."

The H3 No. 2 rocket was decorated with thousands of stickers carrying cheering messages sent from well-wishers around the country.

In its debut flight last March, the rocket had to be destroyed along with its payload, the advanced land observation satellite, or ALOS-3, triggering disappointment and uncertainty about Japan's space exploration plans.

JAXA and MHI have since identified and mitigated the possible electrical issues that led to the failure to ignite H3 rocket's second-stage engine, and carefully rehearsed for the upcoming second test flight. Just to be safe, the rocket this time carried a mockup of the ALOS satellite, called VEP-4, which was not designed to be released.

Iranian Gunman's Kalashnikov Rampage claims 12 relatives

AP
Iran, Feb. 17

A 30-year-old man gunned down 12 of his relatives Saturday in a remote rural area in southeast Iran, the deadliest shooting reported in decades.

Head of the justice department of the province of Kerman, Ebrahim Hamidi, told the semiofficial ISNA news agency the gunman opened fire on his father, brother and other relatives early morning in a village because of family disputes.

The report, which did not identify the assailant, stated he used a Kalashnikov assault rifle.

Local media report on occasional shootings, but this attack has had the highest death toll in Iran, where citizens are only legally allowed hunting rifles, common in rural areas.

In 2022, an employee, who was dismissed from a state-owned financial conglomerate, opened fire at his former workplace, killing three people and injuring another five before killing himself in the country's west.

In 2022, an employee, who was dismissed from a state-owned financial conglomerate, opened fire at his former workplace, killing three people and injuring another five before killing himself in the country's west. In 2016, a 26-year-old man shot 10 relatives in a rural area in the south of Iran.

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In recent years, violence has spiked in the country suffering from deteriorating economic conditions coupled with crushing American sanctions that helped spark soaring inflation and increasing unemployment.

France signs security pact with Ukraine

AFP
France, Feb. 17

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky signed a security pact with France in Paris on Friday, having earlier secured a similar deal with Germany hailed by Chancellor Olaf Scholz as a "historic step" anchoring support for Kyiv in its raging battle against Russia.

The agreement includes a French aid pledge for up to €3 billion for 2024, after €1.7 billion in 2022 and €2.1 billion last year.

Both deals are part of Zelensky's drive to shore up help for his forces who are struggling to hold off Russian attacks on the frontline city of Avdiivka.

After touching down at Orly airport south of the French capital, Zelensky travelled on to the Elysee palace where he met with President Emmanuel Macron to sign the accord.

The French presidency said ahead of the meeting that the pact would run for 10 years, and include precise commitments from the French side, including financial pledges.

It would strengthen cooperation in the area of artillery, the presidency said, without providing details.

The deal is also to help pave the way towards Ukraine's future integration into the European Union and NATO, officials said.

With the Ukraine war about to enter its third year, Zelensky was to make further pleas for sustained help with financing and armaments at the Munich Security Conference on Saturday, where leaders like US Vice President Kamala Harris have gathered.



PHOTO: AFP

French President Emmanuel Macron, right, and his Ukrainian counterpart Volodymyr Zelensky shake hands after signing an agreement on February 16, 2024 at the Elysee Palace in Paris, France.

Zelensky's European tour comes at a critical time with Ukraine facing mounting pressure on the eastern front because of ammunition shortages and fresh Russian attacks.

Fierce fighting raged around the beleaguered frontline town of Avdiivka, which has become a main Russian target ahead of the February 24 invasion anniversary.

The long-term future of billions of dollars of Western aid is meanwhile in doubt, with the biggest contributor, the United States, in the throes of an election year.

A possible $60-billion package of military aid has been held up in Washington since last year because of wrangling in Congress.

The EU has also admitted that it will only be able to make good on half of the one million artillery shells it promised to send by March.

But Scholz underlined that the security pact inked in Berlin on Friday illustrates that Germany will "not let up" in supporting Ukraine. He also announced a new package of immediate military support worth 1.1 billion euros ($1.2 billion).

PRISM

Deer crashes through glass door

South Carolina: Visitors to a South Carolina shopping center got a surprise when a deer crashed through the glass front door of an Old Navy store.

Witnesses said the deer bolted through the door of the Old Navy at Cherrydale Point Plaza in Greenville and became temporarily trapped between the doors in the entryway.

"I looked to my right and saw this deer was trapped," witness Eric Lasker told WYFF-TV. "Poor thing. It was all glass, with two sets of double glass doors leading into the store, so there's glass on all sides and he or she was doing everything to get out."

The deer eventually managed to find its way back out through the broken door.

Woman finds long lost wallet on beach

British Columbia: A woman walking with her dogs on a British Columbia beach made a surprising discovery among the trash that washed up with the tide -- her own long-lost wallet.

Marcie Callawaert said she and her dogs were on the beach of the remote island where she and her husband live near Tofino when she spotted something familiar in the sand.

"I knew right away," Callawaert told CHEK News. "It stopped me right in my tracks."

Callawaert, who chronicled her discovery on TikTok, said she had dropped the wallet into the water while boarding a boat in June 2023.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1797 – French Revolutionary Wars: Sir Ralph Abercromby and a fleet of 18 British warships invade Trinidad.

1900 – Second Boer War: Imperial forces suffer their worst single-day loss of life on Bloody Sunday, the first day of the Battle of Paardeberg.

1911 – The first official flight with airmail takes place from Allahabad, United Provinces, British India (now India), when Henri Pequet, a 23-year-old pilot, delivers 6,500 letters to Naini, about 10 kilometres (6.2 mi) away.

1943 – World War II: The Nazis arrest the members of the White Rose movement.

2003 – 192 people die when an arsonist sets fire to a subway train in Daegu, South Korea.

2014 – At least 76 people are killed and hundreds are injured in clashes between riot police and demonstrators in Kyiv, Ukraine.

Lab-grown diamonds come with sparkling price tags

AP
Philadelphia, Feb. 17

The muted sounds of hammering and sanding drift down to the first floor of Bario Neal, a jewelry store in Philadelphia, where rustic artwork that mimics nature hangs on warmly-lit walls.

Waiting for one of those rings is Haley Farlow, a 28-year-old second grade teacher who has been designing her three-stone engagement ring with her boyfriend. They care about price and also don't want jewelry that takes a toll on the Earth, or exploits people in mining. So they're planning on buying diamonds grown in a laboratory.

"Most of my friends all have lab-grown. And I think it just fits our lifestyle and, you know, the economy and what we're living through," said Farlow.

In the U.S., lab-grown diamond sales jumped 16% in 2023 from 2022, according to Edahn Golan, an industry analyst. They cost a fraction of the stones formed naturally underground.



PHOTO: AP

A man looks at a polished lab-grown diamond at Greenlab Diamonds, in Surat, India.

Social media posts show millennials and Generation Zs proudly explaining the purchase of their lab-grown diamonds for sustainability and ethical reasons. But how sustainable they are is questionable, since making a diamond requires an enormous amount of energy and many major manufacturers are not transparent about their operations.

Farlow said the choice of lab-grown makes her ring "more special and fulfilling" because the materials are sourced from reputable companies. All of the lab diamonds at Bario Neal are either made with renewable energy or have the emissions that go into making them countered with carbon credits, which pay for activities like planting trees, which capture carbon.

But that's not the norm for lab-grown diamonds.

Many companies are based in India, where about 75% of electricity comes from burning coal. They use words like "sustainable" and "environmentally-friendly" on their websites, but don't post their environmental impact reports and aren't certified by third parties. Cupid Diamonds, for example, says on its website that it produces diamonds in "an environmentally friendly manner," but did not respond to questions about what makes its diamonds sustainable. Solar energy is rapidly expanding in India and there are some companies, such as Greenlab Diamonds, that utilize renewables in their manufacturing processes.

China is the other major diamond manufacturing country. Henan Huanghe Whirlwind, Zhuhai Zhong Na Diamond, HeNan LiLiang Diamond, Starsgem Co. and Ningbo Crysdiam are among the largest producers. None returned requests for comment nor post details about where it gets its electricity. More than half of China's electricity came from coal in 2023.

DAUGHTER DIES WHILE MOTHER ATTEMPTING SELF-IMMOLATION INJURED CRITICALLY

RSS
Jhapa, Feb. 17

A daughter died while her mother got critically injured when the mother attempted self-immolation in Jhapa district Friday night.

According to Dundiraj Giri, Police Inspector at the District Police Office, Jhapa, Maya Ramtel, 28, of Gopaldandi of Buddha Shanti rural municipality-2 in the district tried to burn herself and her daughter pouring down petrol.

She had tied her daughter in her body with a shawl during the attempt. Both were critically injured in the incident and were rushed to B and C Hospital. The daughter died this morning while the condition of mother is critical. Most of body parts of Maya were burnt in the fire, said Inspector Giri.

He shared that a suicide note was found nearby the incident site where Maya mentioned that she chose to self-immolate since her husband had an extra marital affair.

Police have arrested Maya's husband Rajan BK and started investigation into the case.

The incident took place when Maya's husband was out of the house, police said.



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

President Ramchandra Paudel observing artworks showcased at Mundum International Painting Exhibition-2080 in Kathmandu on Saturday.

Nature conservation issue of common concern: President

RSS
Llitpur, Feb. 17

President Ramchandra Paudel has said nature conservation has become the issue of common concern and challenges to human beings.

President Paudel shared this while addressing the 'Wildlife Conservation and Environmental Justice' conference jointly organised by the Ministry of Forest and Environment, Judges' Society Nepal and National Trust for Nature Conservation on Saturday.

'Currently, the world is surrounded by environmental challenges including climate change. Nepal is not away from it. National and international concern and interest have increased in the sector of environment and wildlife conservation", he mentioned.

Stating that nature, bio diversity and wildlife conservation are directly connected with sustainable development, the President stressed, "We are aware about the role played by wildlife found in Nepal in balancing ecological system. But people's awareness level about this is more important."

He laid emphasis on the need of effectively addressing the current issues like human-wildlife conflict, smuggling of wildlife, illegal trade as well as management of human-wildlife conflict, wildlife conservation.

"We also should think issues like managing challenges caused by increasing number of wildlife, arrangement of wildlife-friendly physical infrastructures, national capacity building and activeness of state mechanisms as the result of wildlife conservation", added President Paudel.

Sharing that Nepal has achieved remarkable achievement in the nature conservation and there is a possibility of support of this sector in economic development of the country, he requested all to involve in policy-making to its implementation by carrying out detailed analysis of existing challenges and opportunities of wildlife conservation and environmental justice.

The President underscored, "As legal frameworks we establish play a significant role in shaping our conservation efforts.

It is appropriate to engage increasing collective understanding by sharing experiences and strategies focusing on our experiences and problem-solving methods."

Nature-based solutions help better adapt, protect more lives: Speakers

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 17

The speakers Saturday called for integrating anticipatory disaster risk reduction (DRR) and climate change adaptation (CCA) approaches with the climate science to make sure that more lives are protected from climatic disasters.

Speaking at a panel discussion organised at the World Social Forum here today by Pakistan's leading think tank 'Sustainable Development Policy Institute (SDPI) and Oxfam in Pakistan, the speakers said that the incidence of climatic hazards and disasters are increasing which plunge communities into vulnerability to disasters and are causing losses and damages.

Speaking on the occasion, climate justice expert Harjeet Singh said that the temperatures are the determining factor of climate change which calls for analyzing science so that we can better adapt and prepare our communities against climatic hazards and disasters.

He called upon the humanitarian sector to keep in mind the future warming levels and slow on-set of disasters while designing humanitarian programmes. He said the communities know much about impacts of climate change such as glacier melting, changing cropping pattern, water availability, etc., but they do not know why this is happening. Science gives the answer to 'why'. While climate change is creating new poor with more marginalities, there is a need to opt for nature-based solutions for adaptation. He called for integrating humanitarian approaches with science.

Deputy Executive Director of SDPI Dr. Shafqat Munir said that climatic hazards are now putting cities and towns at risk urging the needs for risk-sensitive urban planning through applying both Disaster Risk Reduction and Climate Change Adaptation strategies.

He said preparedness and anticipatory DRR approaches can better equip the vulnerable communities at local levels to cope with ensuing disasters/climatic hazards. The localization of DRR-CCA strategies and implementation plans can help save and protect more lives. He called for taking urgent collective action to achieve the Paris Agreement's objective on Global Goal on Adaptation and Sendai Framework for DRR.

Oxfam's regional humanitarian coordinator Jermaine, from the Philippines, said that effective climate action requires a balanced approach, considering both adaptation and mitigation efforts. Similarly, there is a need to ensure equity, right, and justice in line with the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) framework that prioritizes fairness and equitable adaptation strategies. Quoting from Cyclone Hayan 2013, he said due to inappropriate early warning messaging, the communities could not prepare against the Tsunami. He said that there is a need to train communities on DRR and early warning messaging should be clear.

Programme Manager of ARTS Foundation, Saira Falak, from Pakistan, narrated about the losses and damages that occurred in Pakistan during the floods of 2022. She specially mentioned about the plight of women and girls. She said during the emergency, the women lost their livelihood and plunged into further poverty. She said that there is a need to build capacity of women on disaster risks and preparedness. She spoke about the non-traditional losses which impact people and economy badly.

Civil society activist from Nepal, Ram Sharan Sedhai said disaster creates, perpetuates and aggravates poverty which renders people more vulnerable to disasters and weakens their coping strategies.

Once hit by disaster, the community needs resources, time and patience to recover from the impacts. Talking about Nepal's 2015 earthquake, he said political willpower and stability have far-reaching impacts on decisions regarding saving lives. He called for training the first responders, such as local youth, police, elected representatives, and government.

African leaders condemn Israel's offensive in Gaza

AP
Addus Ababa, Feb. 17

Leaders at an African Union summit in the Ethiopian capital Addis Ababa on Saturday condemned Israel's offensive in Gaza and called for its immediate end.

Moussa Faki, the chair of the African Union Commission, said Israel's offensive was the "most flagrant" violation of international humanitarian law and accused Israel of having "exterminated" Gaza's inhabitants.

Faki spoke alongside Palestinian Prime Minister Mohammad Shtayyeh, who also addressed the summit.

"Rest assured we strongly condemn these attacks that are unprecedented in the history of mankind," Faki said to applause from delegates. "We want to reassure you of our solidarity with the people of Palestine."

Azali Assoumani, president of the Comoros and the outgoing chairperson of the African Union, praised the case brought by South Africa against Israel at the International Court of Justice while condemning "the genocide Israel is committing in Palestine under our nose."

"The international community cannot close its eyes to the atrocities that are committed, that have not only created chaos in Palestine but also have disastrous consequences in the rest of the world," Assoumani said.

A quarter of Gaza's residents are starving because of the war, which began with Hamas' assault into Israel on Oct. 7, in which militants killed about 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and abducted around 250.

Israel strongly denies committing genocide in Gaza and says it does all it can to spare civilians and is only targeting Hamas militants. It says Hamas' tactic of embedding in civilian areas makes it difficult to avoid civilian casualties.

During last year's AU summit, an Israeli delegate was unceremoniously removed from the plenary hall amid a row over the country's observer status at the continental body.

Concern over conflicts and the resurgence of coups across the African continent also underscored the opening of this year's summit. Faki cited tensions over Senegal's postponed election and violence in eastern Congo, Sudan, the Sahel, and Libya. He called for a revival of "the spirit of African solidarity and Pan-Africanism" to overcome the many challenges facing the continent of 1.3 billion people.

NELTA...

opportunities, and effective coping strategies, he added.

Addressing the conference, Speaker of the House of Representatives of Nepal, Devraj Ghimire, said the feedback given by the participants will be fruitful to making new education act as it is in discussion at parliament.

State Minister for Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, Pramila Kumari said that the government is always ready to coordinate with NELTA regarding the issues of teachers in Nepal. Mayor of Lalitpur Metropolitan City Chiribabu Maharjan appreciated the role of NELTA in performing well over community schools across the metropolis.

Mundum int'l...

Around 200 paintings of painters of 50 countries have been put on display in the exhibition. Mayor Tirtha Raj Bhattarai said the expo was organised with an objective of promoting tourism by developing geographical, religious, cultural and tourism sectors of the municipality.

They are confident that the expo would help for social upliftment, he added. The expo will run till February 29. A total of 43 painters including 19 foreigners had drawn 109 live paintings for the promotion of local cultural, religious and tourism areas by visiting different places of the district from October 4-8, 2023.

Construction business amid...

period of the previous year.

According to the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB), private sector credit from BFIs increased by Rs. 192.64 billion (4.0 per cent) in the six months of this year compared to an increment of Rs. 137.33 billion (3.0 per cent) last year. Two years ago, the private sector credit from BFIs in the first half saw an increase of Rs. 492.63 billion (12.1 per cent).

Meanwhile, the lending rate of banks has also been moderated and commercial banks' weighted interest rate has come down to 11.38 per cent in mid-January this year from 12.79 per cent a year earlier. Such rates in development banks and finance companies is 13.14 per cent and 14.09 per cent. However, this is still about two per cent higher compared to the average interest rate of 9.44 per cent in mid-January 2022.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal and Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat have been repeatedly assuring the private sector to keep the interest rate to a single digit.

However, a banker said that the leaders should stop making any promises or claims against the market practice as the interest rates of the bank are determined by the demand and supply in the financial system. Governor of the NRB, Maha Prasad Adhikari has also been voicing the same concern.

Facilitating construction business

The earlier boom in the construction of private houses in Nepal was backed by an inflated profit margin in the real estate business, a booming share market and low-interest loans by the banks.

These opportunities were lost as the real estate and share market crashed with the share market index going below the 1,900 mark from above 3,100 and real estate transactions discouraged by high-interest rates, a ban on splitting land pieces and crisis in the cooperative sector where more than Rs. 75 billion of lower-middle and middle-class people is stuck significant part of which is not likely to be recovered.

A ray of hope is exhibited by the increased remittance inflow which witnessed an upward trend of 25.3 per cent to Rs. 733.22 billion in the first half of the current fiscal year. However, this amount is scattered among millions of households across the country and a large chunk of it is used in financing daily essential goods and paying utility and education bills.

Poudel said that people don't have money to build their houses or even carry any minor construction works like building boundary walls and other maintenance. Meanwhile, the price of house construction has increased to Rs. 4,200 per square foot now from Rs. 3,500 a year earlier.

"There are no symptoms of early improvement in the situation. This is a cross-cutting issue and multiple stakeholders should intensify efforts to weed out the problems and facilitate the business. But in the case of Nepal such cooperation is not forthcoming," said Singh.

Likewise, Thapa of CMA said that the government should devise a better strategy to promote development and construction. There should be an environment to run construction work throughout the year contrary to the current practice of doing it in the second half of the year, he said. He also suggested the government secure domestic or international borrowing to finance development work and offer much-needed impetus to the construction and related industries.

Similarly, according to Murarka, housing loans should be promoted and the NRB directive that bars banks and financial institutions to mobilise loans to a second house of the same person should be revised.

More than 40 per cent of the capital allocation should be utilised in the first half of the fiscal year if the country wants to stimulate rapid development and economic growth. Since the country is in dire need of quality physical infrastructure, public facilities and construction, the government and private sector should find a way to promote sustainable growth in this sector.

Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport (MoPIT), Ministry of Urban Development (MoUD), Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation (MoEWRI), Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies (MoICS), Department of Industry and Investment Board of Nepal at the federal level and provincial infrastructure and industry ministries as well as local bodies should play a proactive role for better mobilisation of the capital budget.

Need for better coordination

Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport, Prakash Jwala, said that the current crisis is a cumulative impact of multiple decisions and problems such as a temporary ban on crusher industries, restriction on land-splitting and poor development expenditure.

"This is not an issue that the Infrastructure Ministry can address single-handedly. Development ministries like MoUD, MoEWRI, and MoICS also spend a large amount of capital budget," he said. "However, we are extending facilitation in resolving the issues in the critical projects like Narayangadh-Butwal Road Expansion."

Minister Jwala said that there have been multiple rounds of discussions with the contractors and other development stakeholders in facilitating the payment and construction. However, these efforts have yet to bear any fruits.

The MoPIT is also struggling to address the demands of the contractors as the latter have asked to provide a blanket solution to the problem which the Ministry is hesitating to accept. It said that only appropriate demands should be addressed.

US aid to Ukraine hinges on House Speaker Johnson

AP
Washington, Feb. 17

When Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy spoke with congressional leaders in Washington late last year he told them privately what is now public: With U.S. weapons, they could win the war against Russia, but without them Russian President Vladimir Putin would be victorious.

In a subsequent meeting with new House Speaker Mike Johnson, a looming deadline for the supplies came into focus. Now, with U.S. aid for Ukraine teetering in Congress, it's up to Johnson to decide what happens next.

The Republican's leadership will determine whether the House will agree to approve more aid for Ukraine or allow the U.S. commitment to wither, the end of the line for the embattled young democracy in Kyiv.

"We have to help now," President Joe Biden implored Congress on Friday from the White House. And Zelenskyy said Saturday at a news conference with Vice President Kamala Harris in Germany that Ukraine was counting on a "positive decision" from Congress for the "vital" aid from its "strategic partner."

The political and policy decisions ahead in Congress are gravely uncertain. Johnson is insisting he won't be "rushed" into approving the $95.3 billion foreign aid package from the Senate, despite overwhelming support from most Democrats and almost half the Republicans. But he has yet to chart a path forward in his chamber.



While many in Congress view Putin as a global threat, particularly after Russia intervened in the 2016 election in favor of Donald Trump, Johnson's colleagues on the far right are increasingly ambivalent about Putin's aggression and authoritarian leadership, as seen in conservative Tucker Carlson's admiring videos from Moscow after his recent interview with the Russian leader.

Even the sudden death of Alexei Navalny, the most famous political prisoner in Russia and Putin's biggest rival, did not appear to move the House speaker Friday to commit to support for Ukraine.

"As Congress debates the best path forward to support Ukraine, the United States, and our partners, must be using every means available to cut off Putin's ability to fund his unprovoked war in Ukraine and aggression against the Baltic states," Johnson, R-La., said in a statement.

Just months on the job, the new speaker is prone to dithering on big questions of the day as he tries to unite his deeply fractured but paper-thin House GOP majority, which is filled with up-and-coming figures challenging his leadership and, at times, threatening his ouster.

In one of his first interviews since taking the gavel in October, Johnson told Fox News' Sean Hannity that Congress was "not going to abandon" Ukraine.

But in the months since, Johnson's bottom-up leadership style, in which he tries to hear out all comers, has created a leadership vacuum on Ukraine aid that others are increasingly willing and able to fill.

Republican Rep. Matt Gaetz of Florida, a Trump ally who opposes more aid to Ukraine, said he hopes to lead a new generation of Republican lawmakers eager to turn away from traditional GOP interventionism around the world.

Gaetz said he believes additional U.S. military aid for Ukraine risks escalating the conflict in ways potentially harmful to Americans.

"And I think that is a lot more significant to my constituents than which dude gets to run Crimea," Gaetz said, referring to the region Russia has claimed from Ukraine as its own.

If the $95 billion aid package was put to a vote, Johnson would find overwhelming support in the House from a coalition of Democrats and Republicans. Anchoring the package is $61 billion for Ukraine, mainly in the form of military equipment from the U.S. It also sends foreign assistance and humanitarian aid to Israel, Gaza and allies in the Indo-Pacific region, including Taiwan.

The Beatles reunited with Paul's stolen bass after over 50 years

AP
London, Feb. 17





PHOTO: THE LOST BASS PROJECT/NICK WASS VIA AP

In this photo released by The Lost Bass Project/Nick Wass on Friday, Feb. 16, 2024, Nick Wass, an executive with Hoefner, inspects Paul McCartney bass.

Paul McCartney no longer gently weeps for his original bass guitar.

A five-year search by the manufacturer of the instrument that was aided by a husband-and-wife team of journalists helped reunite The Beatles star with the distinctive violin-shaped 1961 electric Höfner that went missing a half-century ago and is estimated to be worth 10 million pounds ($12.6 million).

McCartney had asked Höfner to help find the missing instrument that helped launch Beatlemania across the universe, Scott Jones, a journalist who teamed up with Höfner executive Nick Wass to track it down, said Friday.

"Paul said to me, 'Hey, because you're from Höfner, couldn't you help find my bass?'" Wass said. "And that's what sparked this great hunt. Sitting there, seeing what the lost bass means to Paul, I was determined to solve the mystery."

McCartney bought the bass for about 30 pounds ($37) in 1961 when The Beatles were developing their chops during a series of residencies in Hamburg, Germany. The instrument was played on the Beatles first two records and featured on hits such as "Love Me Do," "Twist and Shout," and "She Loves You."

"Because I was left-handed, it looked less daft because it was symmetrical," McCartney once said. "I got into that. And once I bought it, I fell in love with it." It was rumoured to have been stolen around the time The Beatles were recording their final album, "Let it Be," in 1969. But no one was sure when it went missing.

What began as a long and winding road for Wass to track down the bass picked up speed when Jones serendipitously joined the hunt after seeing McCartney headline the Glastonbury Festival in 2022. The stage lights at one point seemed to illuminate nothing but the sunburst pattern on his bass and Jones wondered if it was the same instrument McCartney had played in the early '60s.

When he later searched the Internet he was stunned to find the original bass was missing and there was a search for it.

"I was staggered, I was amazed," Jones said. "I think we live in a world where The Beatles could do almost anything and it would get a lot of attention."

Jones and his wife, Naomi, both journalists and researchers, got in touch with Wass to spread the word more broadly.

After hitting a dead end following a lead about a roadie for The Who, they relaunched The Lost Bass Project in September and within 48 hours were inundated with 600 emails that contained the "little gems that led us to where we are today," Jones said.

One of those emails came from sound engineer Ian Horne, who had worked with McCartney's band Wings, and was the first big breakthrough in the hunt. Horne said the bass had been swiped from the back of his van one night in the Notting Hill section of London in 1972.

The researchers published the new information on their website in October, adding that Horne said McCartney told him not to worry about the theft and that he continued working for him for another six years. "But I've carried the guilt all my life," Horne said.

After publishing that update, a bigger break came when they were contacted by a person who said their father had stolen the bass. The man didn't set out to steal McCartney's instrument and panicked when he realized what he had, Jones said. The thief, who was not named, ended up selling it to Ron Guest, landlord of the Admiral Blake pub, for a few pounds and some beers.

As the Joneses were starting to look for relatives of Guest, word had already reached his family. His daughter-in-law contacted McCartney's studio. Cathy Guest said that the old bass that had been in her attic for years looked like the one they were looking for.

It had been passed from Ron Guest to his oldest son, who died in a car wreck, and then to a younger son, Haydn Guest, who was married to Cathy and died in 2020. The instrument was returned to McCartney in December and then it took about two months to authenticate it.

The project had planned to announce the news but were upstaged by Cathy Guest's son, Ruaidhri Guest, a 21-year-old film student who posted photos Tuesday of the guitar on X, formerly Twitter, and wrote: "I inherited this item which has been returned to Paul McCartney. Share the news." He posted a message Friday saying the family had been inundated with interview requests and would tell its story eventually.

The estimated value of the instrument is based on the fact that a Gibson acoustic guitar Kurt Cobain played on MTV Unplugged sold for $6 million (4.7 million pounds), Jones said. But it held almost no value during the past half-century.

"The thief couldn't sell it," Jones said. "Clearly, the Guest family never tried to sell it. It's a red alert because the minute you come forward someone's going to go, 'That's Paul McCartney's guitar.'"

It is now McCartney's once again. His official website posted a message announcing its return, saying "Paul is incredibly grateful to all those involved."

Yabesh drops fourth single 'Kasari'

BY MANNU SHAHI



Inspired by artists like Jeremy Zucker, Chloe Moriondo, Sajjan Raj Vaidya, Oasis Thapa and VEK, Yabesh Thapa is a singer-songwriter taking the Nepali music industry by storm with a single at a time. Born on August 31, 2002, the singer with his articulate lyrics and enticing melodies engrosses over three hundred eighty-six thousand subscribers on his official YouTube handle.

A follower of the Christian doctrine, the singer was exposed to music early in his life while attending his weekly church services. Highly influenced by his seniors, Yabesh was in grade seven when he initially started writing his original music. Even in the present day, he credits his consistent dedication to writing to be the reason for his success.

The songster debuted in the scene at the age of 16 with his first collaboration 'Prayas' (2018) featuring Pratik Shakya. But things started to align for him only a year later after the publication of his tender love ballad 'Laakhau Hajarau'. Yabesh had also merged with his managing record label Class-X Presentation by this time and the creative amalgamation was all set to bedazzle the industry and more. The singer's discography consists of more than a dozen singles, multiple collaborations and the waterfall release of his debut album "Gham Chaaya" publishing three tracks already.

Exhibiting abundant proficiency and eloquence through his compositions and poetry, Yabesh just at 21 finding this level of success continues to practice humility as a person and explore his curiosity in music as a creative. Even the title for his album "Ghaamchhaya" connotes the uncertainty of life; sun and shade representing the ups and downs the only constant and mutual feelings. Furthermore, the album logo also showcases the (2059 -) sign, illustrating the singer's birth year, his inevitable resolution from the physical realm and his desire to leave behind his artistic legacy.

And the singer is back with his fourth single 'Kasari' from his debut album, written and produced by Yabesh, the audio is mixed and mastered by Kobid Bazra (Bajra Creation Records) featuring Nishad Shrestha on cello and Supriya Shrestha on viola. In just a span of two days the song has already escalated the charts with its present ranking at #11 on Trending for music as per the Nepal moderated YouTube broadcast.

The video is directed and edited by Thomas GM, with Nexal Thapa on cinematography, Dawa Bee as the assistant director, Biten Shrestha on production management; featuring the cast of Nivi Shrestha, Nurbu Gyaljen, Namgyal Dolma, Ram Kumar Limbu and Jog Kumari Limbu.

The tune commences with acoustic guitars emulating a madal-based rhythmic pattern and accompanying piano lines enhancing the intro. The string section and a short vocalize line joins in almost immediately creating an instance of dynamic swell to resolve right with the entry of verse. The verse is soft and highlights the expressive lyrical melodies layered by flowy cello sustains and popish guitar strumming.

The pre-chorus vocal articulation feels like the singer is intentionally about to break his voice with his soft and vulnerable delivery ornamented by loads of vibratos. The chorus features complementing vocal harmonies and very well-executed lyrics, and post-chorus the song reaches its dynamic peak with more room for the arrangement. The entire structure repeats once more and the outro ensues and concludes the song with a final drop of a short chorus stanza.

Pushpa: The Rule will 'play on an international scale': Allu Arjun

AGENCIES
New Delhi, Feb. 17



Allu Arjun's fans are eagerly awaiting the release of 'Pushpa: The Rule'. Recently, the makers released a special poster confirming the release date of the second part. Pushpa 2 is set to hit theatres on August 15, 2024, in multiple languages.

Allu Arjun, who is currently attending the Berlin Film Festival, opened up about Pushpa 3 and also discussed the upcoming film. In an interview with Variety, Allu Arjun said, "You can definitely expect part three, we do want to make it a franchise and we have exciting ideas for the lineup". The actor also spilled the beans about the upcoming second part and said, "Pushpa 2 is going to have a very different shade of Pushpa than what you've seen in 'Pushpa 1,' because it is the lower end of the spectrum that you've seen."

"Till then it was playing on a regional scale, now it will play on a national and international scale. Pushpa 1, police officer Bhanwar Singh Shekhawat, played by Fahadh Faasil, emerges as a thorn in Pushpa's side. The conflict between them is going to "escalate to a much bigger, bigger scale," he added.

Allu Arjun was also felicitated at the India Pavilion during the Berlin International Film Festival. Accepting the honour, he spoke about the richness of Indian Cinema and his aspirations to take Indian Cinema to greater heights in global markets.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: The chatter in your life could presently be overwhelming. It's possible that you need to get away from it all and think things through on your own. No matter how much you trust the opinions of your social network.

TAURUS: Getting to know your goals could be crucial at present. Sure, that will empower you to achieve things that matter to you and maybe even make money in the process.

GEMINI: Living in line with your beliefs could be a high priority for you at the moment. As the passionate Moon in your sign supports the confident Sun in your philosophical 9th house.

CANCER: Presenting an exciting and adventurous image is on the horizon for you. Before you venture outward, however, you might need to deal with your own stuff.

LEO: Putting yourself out there can be rewarding today. You›re well-equipped to work a room and find the person in it who›s the best match for your current needs.

VIRGO: You might currently be wondering what you should do to attract a particular kind of relationship. When you›re working hard toward your goals, you›re exactly where you need to be.

LIBRA: Your desire for pleasure could take on urgency at the moment. Although you might feel obligated to push it aside and devote your attention to your responsibilities instead.

SCORPIO: Connecting deeply with a loved one is on the table today. You may be intensely focused on doing what›s necessary to build security in your relationship.

SAGITTARIUS: A conversation could speedily wander deeper than you expect. Perhaps you›re just having a routine chat with a loved one. As the intimate Moon traipses into your intense 8th house.

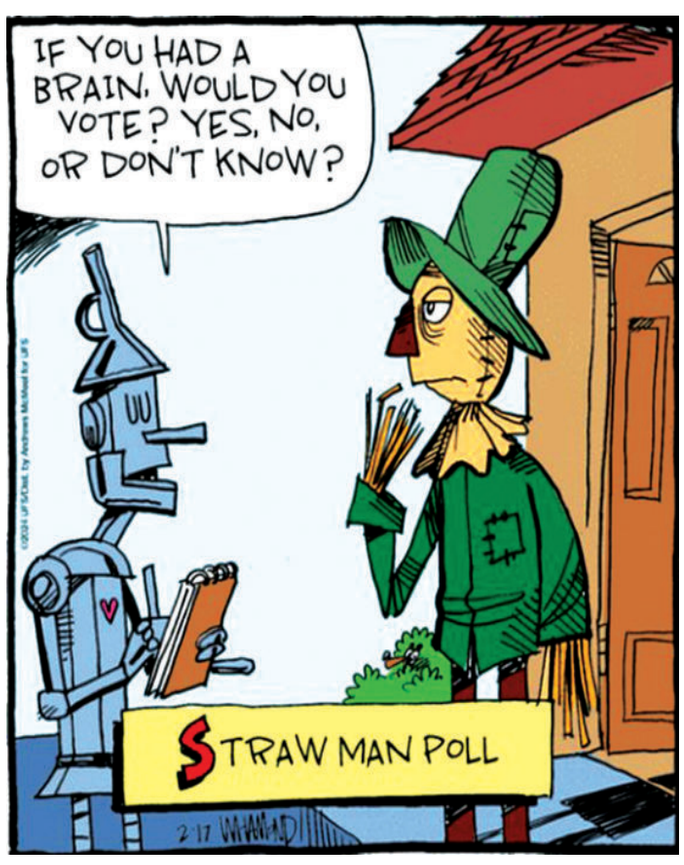
CAPRICORN: Your radar for practical concerns is finely tuned at the moment. As you throw yourself into your duties, however, you'll potentially come to a major realization -- you can't do it all alone!

AQUARIUS: Knowing yourself could be an essential ingredient to your success at this time. When the perceptive Moon in your fun-loving 5th house harmonizes with the optimistic Sun.

PISCES: Surfacing from deep waters is even more refreshing than usual. As the primal Sun moves into your sign, shaking off a stay in your shadowy 12th house, you are in your power position.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal defeats mighty Dutch side by nine wickets

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Feb. 17

The Nepali men's cricket team did not fail thousands of fans who arrived at the TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday to witness Nepal's glorious win against the mighty Dutch side.

Millions of Nepali cricket fans were worried about the match result since Nepal lost bitterly to Namibia, comparably a weaker team than the Netherlands, in the first match of the inaugural ICC CWC League 2 (2024-27) tri-series on February 15.

However, Nepal dominated the Netherlands, a team that defeated South Africa and Bangladesh in the 2023 World Cup, in the second match of the tri-series as the host registered a win by nine wickets on home soil. The Dutch side got bundled at the end of the 39th over and posted a paltry target of 138 runs. Losing only one wicket, Nepal chased the target with 208 balls to spare.

137 all out

Sompal Kami delivered in the first over with the new ball as Nepal won the toss and elected to field. Opener Michael Levitt was caught by Dev Khanal in the third ball of the first over for a duck. While a wicket fell in the first over, the Netherlands still had enough powerful hitters and technical batsmen remaining. Nevertheless, as Max O'Dowd (10 off 21) got run out over a misunderstanding with Sybrand Engelbrecht in the sixth over, Nepal started pushing forward.

Lalit Narayan Rajbanshi opened his account as Sybrand (23 off 35) got caught by Anil Kumar Sah in the 16th over. Moreover, as Lalit bowled dangerous Bas de Leede (24 off 44), ICC Men's Associate Cricketer of the Year 2023, in the 20th over, Nepal saw a chance to restrict the Netherlands to a low total; and Kushal Bhurtel claimed it.

With Noah Croes getting run out in a silly way in the 26th over as the fifth wicket, captain Scott Edwards was all that stood between Nepal's chance to disallow the Netherlands from posting a decent total.



PHOTO: CAN

Anil Kumar Sah (left) and Aasif Sheikh registered individual half-centuries as Nepal defeated the Netherlands by nine wickets in ICC CWC League 2 at TU Int'l Cricket Ground on Saturday.

Edwards lacked a decent batsman to partner with after the team lost five of its top batsmen. Bhurtel, attacking lower-order batsmen, sent Wesley Barresi (0 off 2) and Aryan Dutt (10 off 20) back to the pavilion in the 27th and 33rd overs respectively. Bhurtel went on to take two more wickets as Edwards (33 off 49) was struck leg-before in the 35th over and Vivian Kingma (2 off 17) got stumped in the 39th over as the final wicket leaving the Netherlands at 137 runs. Kyle Klien stayed not out at 11 off 16.

While Bhurtel took four wickets, Lalit bagged two and Sompal claimed one. Bowling only one over, captain Rohit Kumar Paudel bowled out Shariz Ahmed in the 28th over.

Boundaries rain at TU

Getting caught for a golden duck against Namibia, Kushal Bhurtel safely opened his account with a single in the first ball against the Netherlands. Aasif Sheikh, on the other hand, defended the next four balls before hitting a risky four in the final ball of the first over by pacer Kingma.

And the second over of the match, Bhurtel raised the roof at the TU International Cricket Ground as he hit two sixes and a four in the first four balls by spinner Dutt. Rotating the strike with a single, Aasif ended Dutt's over with a four and the duo added 21 runs in the second over of the chase.

As Kingma returned in the third over, Bhurtel welcomed him with a six. Hitting the fourth ball for a four, Bhurtel got caught in the fifth ball as he could not connect the ball for a six properly. Bhurtel departed adding 28 runs off only 11 deliveries. For his aggressive start for the team with the bat and four wickets with the ball, Bhurtel was adjudged the player of the match.

Aasif, who was dropped at 19, then partnered with power hitter Anil Kumar Sah and chased the target in 15.2 overs. Aasif and Anil both registered their half-centuries in a dominant batting display. Anil finished the game with a four, which was the 24th boundary for Nepal. Anil stayed not out at 57 off 36 (6 fours, 4 sixes) and Aasif at 54 off 45 (2 fours, 3 sixes).

Compared to the squad against Namibia, Nepal included Dipendra Singh Airee and Dev Khanal against the Netherlands replacing Karan KC and Pawan Sarraf. Two players – Kyle Klein and Michael Levitt also debuted for the Netherlands in men's ODIs against Nepal.

While Namibia faces the Dutch side on Monday, Nepal will play its second match of the tri-series against Namibia and the Netherlands on February 21 and 25 respectively.

Potential Mbappe arrival excites Madrid fans

AFP
Madrid, Feb. 17

The 25-year-old France captain informed Paris Saint-Germain (PSG) officials he intends to leave in the summer at the end of his contract, a source close to the Ligue 1 champions said Thursday. Madrid is in pole position to sign a player whom they have moved for several times in the past only to be rebuffed, although they declined to comment when asked by AFP.

Spanish media report Madrid's offer to Mbappe is lower than in 2022 when he decided to renew his PSG contract, with Cadena SER saying he wants 50 million euros ($54 million) gross a season along with a hefty 120 million euros signing-on bonus.

Media outlet Marca claimed that Mbappe had already informed club bosses "that he only wanted to play for Real Madrid" and added that he informed the Spanish giants of his decision to leave PSG on Tuesday, 48 hours before it was revealed from a source close to PSG.



Mbappe had the chance to join Madrid from Monaco in 2017 but chose PSG instead, perhaps cowed by the difficulty of ousting Cristiano Ronaldo, Gareth Bale or Karim Benzema from the attack.

Now he could lead the line alongside Vinicius Junior and Jude Bellingham.

"That would be perfect," Luis Caceres, the president of Real Madrid's fan club federation told AFP.

"He's the best player in the world, that's undeniable. We've seen him play and we know what he can do, he's a great player."

Spanish newspaper AS say Madrid will "keep silent" on Mbappe while the two sides are still competing in Europe.

Last June a Real Madrid fan did manage to lure club president Florentino Perez into giving a clue away about Mbappe's future.

Enrique Higueras, 22, stumbled across Perez outside a restaurant and asked him if he would bring Mbappe to the Santiago Bernabeu.

"Yes, but not this year," replied Perez.

Higueras, a student doctoring in sports science, told AFP he believes Mbappe will succeed if and when he arrives, I am sure that he will play at Madrid and make history."

Ancelotti on Mbappe talk

"I can see and hear, I understand it's the topic of the day for you, but not for us, for us it's tomorrow's game," Ancelotti told a news conference ahead of Madrid's visit to face Rayo Vallecano in La Liga.

"People can talk, I understand it's the story of the day ... I want to finish this season well and win titles. There's a lot of time left to think about next season."

Ancelotti said he did not think the league leaders' squad would be affected by rumours and talk surrounding Mbappe in the weeks ahead.

SNIPPETS

Alcaraz, Sinner into respective semis

France (AFP): World number two Alcaraz came through 7-6 (7/1), 6-1 against his 152nd-ranked opponent. Defending champion Carlos Alcaraz reached the semi-finals of the Buenos Aires clay-court tournament on Friday with a straight-sets win over Italian qualifier Andrea Vavassori. Vavassori matched the Spanish star blow-for-blow in the opening set. However, Alcaraz then raced into a 5-0 lead in the second set before sealing victory after an hour and 40 minutes on court. He will face either Chilean third seed Nicolas Jarry or Argentina's Tomas Etcheverry, seeded sixth, for a place in Sunday's title match.

Meanwhile, top seed Sinner took the first set 7-6 (7/4) before the big-hitting 33-year-old Canadian called it quits after two more games. Sinner goes on to face Dutchman Tallon Griekspoor, who defeated Emil Ruusuvuori of Finland, 7-5, 7-6 (7/4) for a place in Sunday's final. Sinner, 22, can take the world number three ranking if he wins the title on Sunday. If that happens, he would become the highest-ever ranked Italian man.

Woods pulls out of Genesis Invitational in 2nd round

Los Angeles (AFP): The US PGA Tour said Woods pulled out after hitting his tee shot at the seventh hole because of illness, with no immediate word on the nature or severity of the trouble. Woods buried his face in his hands as he was ferried from the course in a golf cart, his first official PGA Tour event since he withdrew from the rain-delayed third round of the Masters last April.

Two weeks later Woods had ankle surgery to address lingering pain in his right foot from injuries suffered in a 2021 car crash. Woods has played only nine official events in the last four seasons. He has missed the cut twice and withdrawn three times. Woods said Thursday that back spasms contributed to a surprising shank at the 18th hole of his one-over par first round. The 48-year-old said in December at the unofficial Hero World Challenge that he hoped his various physical problems would allow him to play up to one tournament a month.

India leads by 322 runs on Day 3

AFP
Rajkot, Feb. 17

The hosts reached 196-2 at the end of Day 3 in their second innings at Rajkot after part-time spinner Joe Root dismissed skipper Rohit Sharma lbw for 19 and Rajat Patidar got caught in the ball of Tom Hartley for a duck.

Rohit, who hit 131 in the first innings, missed a sweep and England successfully reviewed the decision after the on-field umpire denied the call.

Yashasvi Jaiswal registered a century before getting retired hurt. Jaiswal left at 104 runs of 133 balls (9 fours, 5 sixes).

Crossing the half-century mark, Shubman Gill (65 off 120) is batting with Kuldeep Yadav (3 off 15) at the end of the day. After bundling out England at 319 runs on Day 3, India now leads the 3rd Test by 322 runs.

Ben Duckett hit 153 and skipper Ben Stokes made 41 in his 100th Test but England lost wickets at regular intervals and their innings ended in the second session.

Siraj wiped out the tail with help from Ravindra Jadeja, who along with fellow spinner Kuldeep Yadav took two wickets each.

Left-hander Stokes attempted to rebuild after Duckett's departure and hit six boundaries.

But he fell to Jadeja's left-arm spin and Siraj sent back wicketkeeper Ben Foakes at the start of the next over as England's batting collapsed. The tourists resumed on 207-2 in reply to India's 445 but lost two wickets in the space of six deliveries inside the first 30 minutes.



PHOTO: AJIT SOLANKI VIA AP

India's Kuldeep Yadav, left, celebrates Ben Duckett's wicket with captain Rohit Sharma.

Jasprit Bumrah struck in the fifth over of the day when Root attempted a reverse scoop and Jaiswal caught it at second slip. Kuldeep got Jonny Bairstow trapped lbw for a duck.

The left-handed Duckett, who smashed 23 fours and two sixes in his 151-ball knock, got to 150 but came to a tame end when he chased a wide delivery from Kuldeep to be caught at cover.

Ashwin left the Test midway "to be with his mother" hours later on Friday and Devdutt Padikkal came in as a substitute fielder. The five-match series is level at 1-1 after England won the opener and India bounced back in the second match.

German fans continue investor protests

AP
Berlin, Feb. 17

Fan protests halted another game in the Bundesliga when supporters threw tennis balls and sent remote control cars careening around the penalty area during Werder Bremen's 1-0 win over Cologne.

The match was halted for almost 10 minutes early in the second half. Fans have been protesting at games across the country against a proposed deal to sell a future stake in the league to a private equity investor.

Players kicked the tennis balls off the pitch as two bright orange cars sped up and down the penalty box doing flips and about-turns.

In previous protests, apples and chocolate coins have been thrown onto the pitch. Last week, a second-division game between Hamburg and Hannover was interrupted after fans attached bicycle padlocks to a goalpost. Officials cut the locks off with a power saw.



PHOTO: AP

Werder Bremen goalkeeper Michael Zetterer hands a steward a remote-controlled car from the pitch during the Bundesliga match against FC Koln at RheinEnergieStadion, Cologne, Germany, Friday.

When Friday's game restarted, Bremen returned to winning ways while Cologne's relegation worries deepened.

Substitute Justin Njinmah scored with 20 minutes remaining. Cologne goalkeeper Marvin Schwäbe missed Mitchell Weiser's cross from the right and Nijnmah turned the ball into the empty net. Bremen climbed into the seventh spot.

The defeat was a blow to Cologne, which appeared to have steadied after a poor run left it in relegation trouble.

Since Timo Schulz took over on Jan. 4, Cologne had lost only once and picked up five of a possible nine points before Friday's reverse.

The inability to score has cost it dearly, and defeat meant it remained third from bottom, six points from safety.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:39 am, Sunset at 5:57 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly to generally cloudy in Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with the hilly region and mainly fair in the rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at one or two places of hilly region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province and Karnali Province and at one or two places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 19 - 21°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.7	8.1	0.0
Dadeldhura	19.8	6.8	0.0
Dhangadi	25.2	10.0	0.0
Birendranagar	25.6	8.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.6	8.9	0.0
Jumla	19.4	-2.4	0.0
Ghorahi	23.6	9.8	0.0
Pokhara	23.4	11.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.5	8.6	0.0
Simara	25.5	10.5	0.0
Kathmandu	22.5	7.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.5	8.3	0.0
Taplejung	18.4	9.4	0.0
Dhankuta	22.6	11.0	0.0
Biratnagar	25.5	14.0	0.0
Jomsom	14.2	-1.0	0.0*
Dharan	25.0	14.5	0.0*
Janakpur	28.2	13.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.2	1.2	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 18, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.53	Rs. 133.13
Euro	1	Rs. 142.77	Rs. 143.42
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.89	Rs. 167.64
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 150.41	Rs. 151.10
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.48	Rs. 86.87
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.31	Rs. 98.76
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.47	Rs. 98.92
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.82	Rs. 8.86
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.42	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.34	Rs. 35.50
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.34	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.68	Rs. 3.69
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.08	Rs. 36.25
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.72	Rs. 27.85
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.94	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.75
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.15	Rs. 19.24
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.94	Rs. 17.02
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.26	Rs. 432.21
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.56	Rs. 353.15

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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